it's not real, and you don't exist.

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44865424.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), Original Characters, Octavia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
mentions of adora - Freeform, Mentions of Shadow Weaver, Mentions of Horde Prime - Freeform, Graphic, i think, Violence, Gore, Catra suffers, like actually, tgcf au, no tgcf knowledge needed though, Hell, catra goes through hell, Isolation, Hurt No Comfort, if i forgot to tag stuff im sorry

Language:
English

Series:
Part 7 of oh i may weep forevermore (my love will never die)

Stats:
Published: 2023-02-08 Completed: 2023-04-15 Words: 34,620 Chapters: 5/5

it's not real, and you don't exist.

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44865424.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), Original Characters, Octavia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
mentions of adora - Freeform, Mentions of Shadow Weaver, Mentions of Horde Prime - Freeform, Graphic, i think, Violence, Gore, Catra suffers, like actually, tgcf au, no tgcf knowledge needed though, Hell, catra goes through hell, Isolation, Hurt No Comfort, if i forgot to tag stuff im sorry

Language:
English

Series:
Part 7 of oh i may weep forevermore (my love will never die)

Stats:
Published: 2023-02-08 Completed: 2023-04-15 Words: 34,620 Chapters: 5/5

it's not real, and you don't exist.

by orphan_account

Summary

"Make 'em pay for what they did to us, kid!" Imara yells, passion embedded in her voice. "Mercier, is his name!"

"...Mercier, as in King Mercier of Salineas?" She asks blankly. "The fucking Water Master?"

"You bet your little ghost ass right!" Imara exclaims. "Shady businessman, that one."

She was at a loss for words. Imara, however, was evidently not, "And when you get that slimy piece of shit, tell 'em that Imara sent you from hell!"

or, the story of the worst 10 years of Catra's afterlife.

Notes

For this entire first chapter, Catra does not go by the name "Catra"!!! Just wanted to let you guys all know that ahead of time. fic title comes from "Ceilings" by Lizzy McAlpine.
Chapter title comes from the english translation of Dead Man Runnin' by Seulgi!
Hope you all enjoy this chapter <3

See the end of the work for more notes

My eyes in the mirror, they are cold (what are they looking for?)

"No need to fear!" he had called. "Don't worry. A new ghost king hasn't left Mount Tong'lu in over seven centuries. What makes this time any different?"

And, they listened. Who were they to not listen to the emperor himself?

What fools they were.

—

When she woke, it was not in the town that she had been dispersed in. It was not her old quarters in the Fright kingdom- not even a torn down and charred temple dedicated to *her,* the very temple in which she was born as a Savage ranked Ghost.

CLANG!

She was in a room, laying on the floor it seemed. The walls were red, and the floor was velvety in touch. She was thoroughly confused. Where was she? How did she end up here? *Why* is she here? How is she not gone for good? She was sure her soul was dispersed this time so… how was she in this random room?

CLANG! CLANG! CLANG!

“You stupid idiot! You missed your opening! Are you blind!?” A voice yells. “And you missed it again!”

“ARGH! You don’t think I already know that!?” Another voice screams back, sounding out of breath and even a little tired.

CLANG!

“It’s no use,” The first voice drawls. “Just tap out now to regain your energy and challenge it again later.”

Before the second voice can respond, she hears a squeal followed by a thudding sound. “....Or not.” mutters the first voice.

She sits up then, looking around. A woman with pale skin and dark rimmed eyes stares back at her with a raised eyebrow. The woman had shoulder length, thin black hair with two white pieces sticking out on the sides. She had strikingly yellow eyes and a claw scar going straight through her face.

“Look who finally woke up.” The black haired woman said, crossing her arms over her chest. Farther away, a woman on the ground sits up and looks over in their direction. “Is it the girl?”

The woman on the ground had brown hair and purple eyes, with some kind of corruption going up her left arm. Around her shoulder, the corruption faded out and blended in with her skin.

To say she was confused was an understatement.

“Yup,” The black haired woman says. “Which door do you think she’ll go through, Myla?”

She looks up. The ceilings of the room were so high that she couldn’t even see them, yet there was no sunlight. The only light in the room was green and ghastly- ghost fires.

Two doors stood next to each other, one was a deep red, almost maroon in color, while the other was a bright white.

She stands up slowly, softly touching her own arms and the like. She was checking for damage- there was no way she could be alive. No way, not after what happened. But.. strangely enough, she feels fine- she feels intact, and whole. She touches her face and- her scars, gone. The bump on her nose from when she broke it wasn’t there anymore. Her jawline felt sharper, and in general her face felt.. Different.

She looks at the black haired girl. “Where am I?”

The black haired woman blinks at her, “You know you’re dead, right?” The woman asks.

The brown haired woman- Myla, she presumes -stands up now and stands next to the black haired woman. She can see now that Myla is a few inches taller than the black haired woman.

“I’ve been dead before,” She snarls. “I never ended up here.”

“Oh..” Myla looks down at the shorter woman. “I think this one must have been a pretty strong ghost…”

“It doesn’t matter!” the shorter one barks. “She still managed to end up here, with the likes of us, didn’t she?”

She glances over the two of them, and judging by their gear… She can guess what happened to both of them.

“Gladiators?” She guesses with a laugh and an eye roll. “What, you two got too in over your heads and ended up dead?”

The shorter woman scowls. “Hey! You better respect your elders-” She huffs. “I’m Imara, and this one is Myla. You are to *respect us* , got it?”

Myla nods, though she was positioned to be behind Imara. Imara rolls her eyes, "What are you cowering for, 'La?"

"..I don't think this kid is normal, Imara…"

Imara turns her head over her shoulder to look at Myla, "Yeah, no shit! She's dead!"

"No, I mean *besides* being dead!" Myla cries. "Can we just go back to planning? I promise I won't miss my opening this time!'

"Neither of you answered my question." She drawls. "What is this place?"

"I don't talk to strangers." Imara snaps. "What's your name, kid?"

That was a great question. What was her name? She couldn't use her mortal name- no, not anymore. That name didn't belong to her anymore.

"...Wu Ming."

Imara glances at Myla, then bursts into laughter. "Wu Ming!" Imara exclaims. "Did you hear that, Myla? Her name is Wu Ming!"

“Doesn’t that mean anonymous in the Kingdom of Snows dialect?” Myla asks sheepishly. Wu Ming nods with a roll of her eyes.

Eventually, Imara calms down and wipes the tears from her eyes dramatically. “Oh, wow! That was the hardest I’ve laughed in… oh gods, four decades?” She says. “That’s pathetic. Wu Ming? You don’t have a name? What kind of name is that?”

“...My name was stolen from me.” She responds. “I cannot answer to my mortal name, nor can I speak it anymore.”

“Well, if it’s anything like Wu Ming, you should be grateful,” Imara informs, uncrossing her arms. “Wu Ming is *not* a real name. Who the hell gave you that kind of name?”

“That’s none of your concern!” Wu Ming yells. Imara rolls her eyes.

“Let’s do our good deed of the century, ‘La.” Imara nudges her friend with her elbow. “Let’s give this kid a name to use, at least until she picks a *gods damn door.”*

“I don’t *need* you to pick a name for me!” Wu Ming exclaims. “My name is perfectly fine!”

“She’s feisty, isn’t she?” Myla comments. “How about Ardere?”

“Old Eternian, I like it..” Imara mutters, looking over Wu Ming while tapping her chin. “And it means ‘burn’ or ‘scorch’... I approve. Ardere it is!”

…So her name was Ardere now.

“Are either of you going to answer my question!?” She snaps, her temper flaring.

“..And she’s demanding,” Imara grimaces. “Look around, kid.”

“You think I didn’t already do that?” She responds. Imara shrugs her shoulders, “I don’t know. Maybe you missed something, considering you seem to be half fuckin’ blind.”

She doesn’t have the opportunity to quip back at Imara, as she starts speaking,

“That door over there?” Imara says, pointing at the red door. “That goes to the shit hole.”

“...The shit hole?” Ardere repeats. Imara makes a face as if to say *‘isn’t it obvious?!”*

“You wanna be chased around a maze by your worst memories for an eternity?” Imara glares at her. “It’s a shit hole!”

“Why would anyone choose to go through that door?”

“No one does.” Myla says sadly. “We don’t have a choice, most of the time.”

“What do you mean?” Ardere asks. “You don’t have a choice?”

“No ashes, no choice.” Myla shrugs. “If your ashes aren’t intact, and you were a bad person… you’ll get dragged into there.”

She eyes that door and distantly wonders how she hasn’t been dragged into it yet. Her ashes were probably gone, and she was (and still is) a terrible person. She didn’t want that.

“And the white door?” Ardere asks, ripping her eyes away from the red door.

“Starting over.” Imara answers.

Ardere scowls. She didn’t want to start over, either.

“What are you two doing here?” Ardere crosses her arms over her chest. “How come you two haven’t gone through a door?”

“We can’t go through the white door,” Myla responds. “Our ashes were scattered.”

Ardere’s eyes widen. Those two managed to get their ashes scattered?

“Not for anything bad, kid,” Imara quickly adds. “This one got us into a mess we couldn’t dig ourselves out of. Signed us up for a mission only a fool would take!”

“You just called yourselves fools.” Ardere points out.

“We’re unlucky fools,” Imara shrugs. “What else can I say?”

Ardere looks between the two of them, waiting for some kind of elaboration.

“I died first,” Myla sheepishly raises her hand. “She tried to avenge me.”

Ardere nods, understanding now. “So… she went on some gladiator mission, I assume?” She asks, then continues when she gets a nod from them both. “She went on a death mission.. And you tried to avenge her, by….?”

“Assassinating the guy who put up the mission request, duh!”

“...And you died because of a poorly executed assassination attempt?” Adere asks, just to confirm. Imara nods pridefully, “Damn right I did! That wretched piece of shit– I hope he burns in hell! He doesn’t deserve anything that he has! I’d do it all over again!”

Ardere raises her eyebrow, but stays silent as Imara keeps on ranting, “Those sacks of shit! That whole family- they think they’re so above it all, just because they’re wealthy. Actin’ as if he doesn’t put out hits on people that have spoken out against him and his dealin’s… he’s trashy, that’s what he is! He ain’t for the people- anyone in the lower class can say that!”

“So, they scattered your ashes for the assassination,” Ardere clarifies. “But why were her’s scattered?”

“...I said it was in her name.”

“And now we’re here!” Myla exclaims, almost happily. Ardere finds herself frowning, upset for the two of them. She felt bad enough

for Myla, who got her ashes spread simply by association- but she felt even worse for Imara.

Ardere loathed to admit she felt a certain kind of… kinship, to Imara. Her and Imara essentially died the same death- how was she supposed to not feel bad?

“So now neither of you can reincarnate?”

Imara nods. “Can’t reincarnate ‘cause of those asshats, but since neither of us did anything particularly bad, we haven’t been dragged into the red door yet either. We’re stuck in the inbetween.”

Ardere isn’t sure if being stuck in purgatory is any better of a fate than the ‘shit hole’.

“What happens if you don’t want to go through either?” Ardere questions. “What’s the third option?”

“Third option?” Imara looks her up and down in a judgemental way. “Kid, you’re funny. *This* is your third option.”

“Talking to the both of you?” Ardere returns the look. “Yeah, I think I’ll pass.”

Ardere revels in the way Imara's composed demeanor deteriorates into one of rage. "Fine! Fuck you too, kid!"

"Imara!" Myla cries. "She didn't mean it like that, I'm sure!"

"Oh, don't be so naive!" Imara huffs. "You know, you're always the one saying I need to be *vulnerable* and expand my social circle- but look what happens when I try!"

"Is there no way out?" Ardere asks, looking around the barely lit room, looking for another exit that isn't either of the aforementioned doors. Myla just shrugs, "Pretty much."

"You're not gonna go through the white door?" Imara asks after calming herself down. Ardere shakes her head no. Imara looked taken aback, "Are you kidding? How ungrateful can you be! Look at the shape your form is in- If you reincarnate, you could be born rich! Beautiful! Fuck- you could even be a princess!"

"Why do I need to be a princess when I have already served one and know what the life of royalty is like?" She asks, deadpan. The two ghosts in front of her simply stare at her, unblinking. She shrugs her shoulders, "I'm not in the mood to reincarnate. Can't I just go back?'

"...I-" Myla begins, then shakes her head. "Why would you even want to?"

“I have unfinished business.”

“Not if you’re here, you don’t!” Imara exclaims. “Kid, you realize your soul is essentially dispersed? And, judging by this form you’re in, you died pretty heroically.”

“And?”

“Most savage ranked ghosts don’t have the luxury of coming here after being dispersed,” Myla explains. “This is pretty big, you know.”

“Great, cool,” Ardere says. “Wouldn’t work for me either way, if I reincarnated.”

“Cause you’re not at peace?” Myla asks. Ardere nods her head. The two ghosts had nothing to say to that.

“So, how do I get out besides going through the white door?” She asks again.

“There’s only one other way out.” Myla answers. Ardere raises an eyebrow, “Name it.”

Imara motions around herself, “Look around, kid! You’re lookin’ at it!”

Ardere looks around, not seeing much of anything until she hears breathing. Heavy breathing, of something that seemed pretty large.

“You place bets, and then you fight Cerberus.” Imara explains. “That’s your way out.”

“Who are you betting against?” Ardere asks, squinting her eyes to try and look at the beast. Imara just shrugs, “I don’t fuckin’ know. The universe? Whatever god runs this place?”

“The last guys in here explained it pretty easily!” Myla throws in. “You bet parts of your soul, then you fight Cerberus. If you win, you get to make a wish. You are able to tap out, but that means forfeiting which means you lose whatever you bet.”

“Who were the last two?” Ardere asks.

“There used to be four of us but they….” Imara trails off, a faraway look in her eyes. Ardere can guess what happened- they ran out of parts of their souls to bet and vanished. Ardere stays quiet for a moment, weighing her options, before speaking again.

“So,” She says. “To get out of here, all I have to do is bet against Cerberus with parts of my soul?”

“That’s about right, yeah.” Myla confirms. Ardere nods her head absentmindedly. Then, the two ghosts watch solemnly as she reaches for the sword at her waist.

If there was one thing she was known for in her mortal (and even afterlife), was her insanely terrible luck. She knew the two ghosts could smell it on her, too. They were sympathetic, she was sure.

“You have to say your bets out loud?” She asks, stepping closer to where she presumed the beast to lay.

“Yeah, you can.” Imara says. “You know, kid, reincarnation really isn’t-”

“Your odds go up the more weight you place on your bet as well, right?”

She’s never bet before- never had a need to gamble for anything. She was just guessing, really- saying whatever she thought sounded about right.

“That’s right,” Myla confirms, suspicious of the girl slowly stalking towards Cerberus. “...What are you going to do?”

“Right, then,” Ardere decides suddenly, standing in front of the large three-headed dog spirit. “All or nothing. I bet my entire soul.”

That puts her odds as high as they’ll ever get, and she might as well not waste any time. The two women were getting on her nerves, and she wanted out *now.*

“YOU’RE WHOLE SOUL!?” Imara screeches. “KID, ARE YOU INSANE? YOU COULD BE RICH! BEAUTIFUL! A PRINCESS- A FUCKIN’ PRINCESS!”

She lunges at the spirit, aimed to slash directly at the thing's stomach. She figured its stomach and legs would be the two most guarded places- therefore making them the most liable to taking it down.

Cerberus wasn’t expecting such an attack straight out of the gate, thus didn’t accurately defend itself. Ardere slash a cut straight through the spirits stomach, then wasted no time in attacking its leg. She quickly surveyed which leg it put most of its weight onto- the back right leg -and stabbed at it. The three-headed beast howls painfully while wobbling, trying its best to stay up right after getting its support leg gravely injured. Ardere knew, though. It wouldn’t be able to. She began to walk away from it, hearing as it roared in pain. When she was just about out from under it, she heard it howl one last time before-

BANG!

She stopped in her tracks, turning around to eye Cerberus, who was now whimpering on the floor in pain. She threw her now dirty sword to the side to signal the fight was over.

Ardere looks back to the two ghosts, who were watching blankly, shocked.

"Your-" Imara exclaims. "You're fuckin' kidding me! We've been down here for decades, and this nut case just strolls in here, bets her whole soul for a wish, and *wins* within 20 minutes!"

She nods, as if this was the natural order of things. "I'm out of here." She says. "Good luck to you two, though. I'm sure you'll get out eventually."

"You realize that thing's aren't gonna be easier when you get out of here?" Myla asks, genuinely concerned. Ardere ignores them, simply walking towards them- then past them towards the door that was manifesting next to the white one. This one, the new door, was black.

These two were annoying, and she wasn't particularly a person to grant favors but… they did help her get out of her. She generally believes in returning favors to people, especially those who help her so greatly.

“Back in the mortal realm,” Ardere calls behind her, hand on the third door’s handle. “Is there anything you two want done?”

“Make ‘em pay for what they did to us, kid!” Imara yells, passion embedded in her voice. “Mercier, is his name!”

“...Mercier, as in King Mercier of Salineas?” Ardere asks blankly. “The fucking Water Master?”

“You bet your little ghost ass right!” Imara exclaims. “Shady businessman, that one. Sent out a bunch of his lower class citizens on death missions to root out the poverty issue. Ain’t he a nightmare?”

Ardere was at a loss for words. Imara, however, was evidently *not,* “And when you get that slimy piece of shit, tell ‘em that Imara sent you from hell!”

Ardere doubts the Salineas King remembers either of them, but she relents nonetheless, “Fine.”

She turns back to the door, eyeing it. She bites her lip, a little nervous. She was anxious about what awaits her through the door.

“Good luck,” Myla calls sweetly. “I’m sure you’ll be great, with whatever you do.”

Ardere finds herself smiling, but she doesn’t respond to the ghost.

She opens the door and walks through it.

Presented in front of her is a staircase- winding up from whatever pit she seems to be in. Each step is steeper than the last, with no railing to it, tempting the traveler to fall off the edge and back into the room.

The road out of hell is a long and grueling climb. She’d walk it as many times as she has to, she’s decided.

She’d show all of them- show Adora, show Shadow Weaver, show the Horde Kingdom as a whole -that she didn’t *need* them to succeed. She had something to prove, and she was determined to prove that the second she made it back into the mortal plane.

She was absolutely sure of it.

i'm fine with my spite

Chapter Summary

> "I think I'd rather go back to hell than refer to you at all."
>
> His smile drops. "Tread very lightly, little sister," He replies solemnly. "I have more power than you think I do."

Chapter Notes

> sorry this took me sooooo long! but I'm back!
> hope you guys enjoy this, it's a short one!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She finds herself on the landing of the stairwell, face to face with another door. She presses her hands flat against the door and pushes.

In front of her is a long road on an incline. She stood there, staring at the road. The sky was dull and gloomy, gathering storm clouds. The transition from the stairway out of hell to (what she presumes is) the mortal realm was jarring- it took her a second to adjust to her surroundings, adjust to the feeling of not being as powerful as she was in hell.

Tilting her head to the side curiously, she finds that oddly enough… hordes of ghosts are traveling up the road, all in a haste.

One such ghost, in more of a hurry than the rest, bumps right into her. "Hey!" The ghost yells. "How about you pay attention to

where you’re going before stopping in the middle of the road, you-”

She turns to look at the ghost, one yellow eye lighting up the ghost's face in the gloomy atmosphere. The ghost laughs nervously, “A-Actually, nevermind, nevermind! I think I’ll watch where I’m going. My apologies, young master!”

She raises an eyebrow at the ghost. That’s a new name- she’s never been referred to with respect before, not unless it was from her. She’s been called a plethora of names- useless, a monster, an abomination, ineffective, just to name a few -but “young master” has never been one. She was taken aback by such a thing. She looks around the road again, glances at the gray sky.

“Where are they all going?” She asks, watching the gaggle of ghosts hurrying forwards, some even getting trampled in their efforts to advance. The ghost looks at her, baffled. “You don’t know?” The ghost asks. She shakes her head no.

“...Horde Prime, he’s dead,” The ghost says, fidgeting in place, visibly eager to continue the march forward.

“Really?” She’s surprised by such a statement. For as long as she’s been around- as a mortal and as a ghost -Horde Prime has been a staple of the war. “Fight to honor the Emperor of the Known Universe’s legacy!” the war propaganda within the Fright Kingdom would read. To think such a staple, a figurehead, was dead? It was news to her. “How?”

“Struck down by Eternia,” The ghost explains, shaking and quivering. She supposes she can understand whatever fear the ghost had- if the strongest Ghost King there was can be struck down, what did that mean for the rest of them?

“Was it by…” She can’t bring herself to say the words. She has to stop before forcing them out, “Was it Adora?”

The ghost looks at her confusedly before bursting out laughing. “Her!?” The ghost exclaims incredulously, “Please! No one’s seen that loser in-”

Before she can even register it happening, her hands are around the ghost’s neck and squeezing. The ghost dissipates within seconds. Even after the ghost is gone, her fists remain clenched at her sides. She turns and grabs another meek-looking ghost out of the crowd- who now looks terrified, to say the least.

“Who killed the Emperor of the Known Universe?” She asks, still gripping onto the ghost's arm. The ghost looks down at where She was grabbing it, then back at her in fear.

“T-The Eternian Emperor did!” The ghost answers, voice shaky. She raises a brow then, “And what of… Adora?”

“She hasn’t been seen in two decades!” The ghost quivers. “She gained a title- She-ra, Princess of Power!”

She scoffs internally, because of course she would get such a frivolous and Princessy title like “Princess of Power”. Was it supposed to be menacing? It just sounded funny to her.

“What does the death of Horde Prime have to do with… this.” She asks, motioning to everything around them.

“...He was the only Ghost King in existence,” The ghost says. “There must be another..”

“Ghost King?” She questions, testing the feel of the word in her mouth. She used to look up to Horde Prime- back when she was a knight. She wanted to do good by him, whatever good was back then. She worshiped him like one would worship one of the Eternian Gods- in her twisted mind, she believed if she prayed to him for help, he would answer. He didn’t- he never did. Never would.

And, when she went insane, she turned to the Demonic realm even more so. Who needed Eternia, who needed Gods? Gods did not answer prayers, they were too self-centered and concerned with themselves than to save the common people. Gods were all terrible people, in her eyes. If the gods were terrible, then by proxy the demonic realm would be better- full of corruption, yes, but less than Eternia.

She breaks out of her own thoughts when she remembers just what led her on this spiral, “One is about to be born?”

“You could say that,” The ghost agrees. “..When it opens, whoever is remaining will be reborn as the Ghost King.”

“It?” She asks. “When what opens?”

The ghost cranes its neck to look behind them- she tracks it’s movements then, looking further down the path and squinting her eyes- they adjust, then, zooming in on the distance- A mountain. Then, the shrieking of blades scraping against each other, of screams just beyond the mountains.

She curses the fact that she was bare of any and all weapons.

“...The kiln,” The ghost replies shakily. “Just ahead, past the mountains.”

She follows the directions again, and she can guess what “the kiln” is- a volcano. The ground rumbles as more ghosts approach, and she can see the smoke funneling into the air far in the distance, now. That explains the gloomy weather, she supposes.

She already knew what being Ghost King meant- being the most powerful demonic entity there was. She didn’t need to ask any

kind of question about that- she knew first hand from the stories she'd hear from Shadow Weaver.

She listens again, hears the agonized screams even closer.

"What's with the screaming?" She asks, a biting tone to her voice. "Is there fighting?"

"The- the more ghosts you kill, the better your chances are," The ghosts replies. "Something about… absorbing their powers for your own benefit!"

She was not an unreasonable girl. Well, before she went insane, that was.

"Your help is appreciated," She'd rather die again than ever thank someone. "I'll reward you in an exchange; I'll let you go, and you'll turn back now… and I won't swallow you whole. How does that sound?"

The ghost wastes no time in turning back, a few other ghosts near them doing the same at the threat.

She turns her attention back to the path ahead of her- to the path to the kiln.

Of course, this was going to be incredibly inconvenient without a weapon but… she was a savage ghost, albeit severely weakened, but still stronger than the rest on this path. She could feel it.

Besides, she is a skilled warrior- and past that, she is a ghost now. She figures she can twist her form into something that'll give her an advantage until she's strong enough to not need a weapon…

She begins her trek forwards again, willing her fingers to contort into talons- or, well, more like claws. She figures if she really needs it, she can use her teeth too…

She charges forward- she's not sure how long she's on that road, tearing through and absorbing the power of each malice and menace ranked ghost she demolished. It could've been hours, it could've been days- she couldn't tell you.

She felt the strength returning to her ghostly body, it even manifested in heightened senses. A sharpened sense of sight, of hearing even- though the strengthened hearing was only minimal.

She counted around two hundred ghosts that she pummeled- and there was still more. So, so many more. Millions- maybe even more -that have gathered for this occasion, all for the same thing: to gain an inconceivable amount of power. It's overwhelming, in a sense, but she knows- She knows they'll all be consumed by her, one way or another.

She will be the only one remaining out of the millions. She has to be- she has to. Has to prove to Eternia that they aren't shit, that she doesn't need Adora to succeed, doesn't need Shadow Weaver to be great.

She can be great all on her own. She can be powerful without their help, because truth be told, she never needed their help. She never will need their help.

She stands atop a rock, surveying the area. She can pick out how many savage ghosts are within the arena- as she's calling it, to make things more interesting -just by scent alone. She picks out 5 savage ranked ghosts that will present a challenge, but the rest will be like twigs beneath her boots.

One smells mildly familiar, but is so far in the distance that she can't place who they are.

The ghosts below can't see her- out of their own ignorance, or maybe they're choosing to ignore her. It doesn't matter, in the end. She continues to watch, to observe, thinking…

Of the five savage ranked ghosts, she believes two to be stronger than her- so naturally, she'd need to gain enough strength before seeking them out and-

"Well, aren't you a… peculiar one, hm?" A deep voice drawls behind her. She goes completely rigid, not having sensed anyone

creeping up behind her.

She wasn't going to go out easily.

She reared on the person, extending her claws to tear into them. However, when she goes to grip the person- a man -throat, she finds herself… stuck. Unable to move.

The last time she was subject to such a spell was when she was alive, with Shadow Weaver.

"Easy there, tiger." The man says. He's tall, robotic looking with a bandage over his eyes and what she thinks are bloodstains just beneath the bandage. His hair was pure white, completely blending in with his skin, but she could see where his hair began and his forehead ended. He looked… oddly similar to the Lord of the Known Universe.

He wore white robes with black and gray detailing them- not mourning robes, but close enough.

The man tilts his head to the side, hand on her shoulder, and a creepy smile paints his face. "You've made it to the other side before, haven't you, sister?"

She snarls at him. "I'm not your sister. And how would you know that?"

The man just huffs a laugh as he brings his hand from her shoulder to her face, feeling. When he was done, he leaned in, inches from her face, “I can smell it on you, little sister.” He whispered.

He was still smiling, with crooked teeth and… she thinks there is blood slipping out from between his teeth. She elects to not pay any mind to that fact, instead choosing to keep evaluating him.

The power that radiated off of the man was delicious. She could strike, devour him, and easily be the most powerful in the arena. She also figures that, well, if she doesn’t attack first- he definitely will… yet, he doesn’t seem too interested in that facet of things.

His hand is back on her shoulder but with less strength behind it. “It’s rare for a soul to come back after being dispersed, you know.” He takes a deep breath now, seemingly inhaling her scent and exhaling dreamily.

“Why, what a curse on you, little sister!” He exclaimed delightfully. “I wonder wh-”

She had half a mind then, to lunge and try to enact her plan. He catches her by the throat though, throws her onto the ground with enough force to fracture the rock beneath her.

“Do not interrupt when I speak, little sister.” He says it so calmly, with so much contempt, that she had no other option that to comply with his words. He smiled down at her, seemingly knowing where she was without even being able to see. “Good. What’s your name, little sister?”

“...I don’t have one.” She finally responds. He scowls at her, sighs deeply and kicks her in the side, as a punishment of sorts.

“Of course you do, little sister,” He says easily. “Every ghost has one. So let me ask again, what is your name?”

“I don’t have one!” She yells. He goes to inflict another injury upon her, only to stop short and tilt his head. “Hm,” He hums. “The curse I smelt on you. What is it, little sister?”

“My name was stolen.” She growls, not wanting to tell this mysterious ghost anything but having no other choice. “That must be the curse you smelt.”

“Cruel,” He comments. “Tell me your mortal name, little sister. That kind of magic doesn’t work within these walls.”

“Why should I tell you?” She barks out. Next thing she knew, the ghosts boot was on her chest, pressing her into the ground as he towered over her.

“Rule number one to being a ghost, little sister,” He seethed out impatiently. “You want people to know your name.”

She stares up at him, trying to muster as much hate as she can, but she doesn't think he can see it anyway.

“C’yra.” She spits out like a curse.

The man nods and steps off of her, makes a quick movement with his hand and soon she was back on her feet.

“Rule number two,” He says easily, all anger dissipated seemingly. “If you leave this place, you rename yourself. Your ghost self is a different person from your mortal self- no relation except in body.”

“Not like I really had a choice in the first place.” She grumbled. He smiles at her, the same spine-chilling smile from before.

“Very well,” He nods approvingly. “You may call me Shanyuan- or big brother, if you so choose.”

“I think I’d rather go back to hell than refer to you at all.”

His smile drops. “Tread very lightly, little sister,” He replies solemnly. “I have more power than you think I do.”

She was slightly horrified at his thinly veiled threat, and she decided she’d heed his warning. She needed to get out of this place, anyways. Can’t escape if she’s been devoured by a nutcase.

She decided she’d still prod at him, though.

“If knowing a ghosts name is so important, how come I’ve never heard of you, big brother?”

She says it mockingly, but his smile only widens. “Weaker ghosts like yourself need name recognition.”

“Okay,” She resigns. “What the hell is this place?”

“Why have you come here, little sister?” He deflects. She scowls, “The same reason as you.”

She watches as his face somehow hardens. “This is my home, little sister C’yra,” He says almost robotically. “I have lived here for… centuries.”

She furrows her brows, then. For the first time since she’s entered, she takes the time to look around and finally recognizes it for what it is- a destroyed city, buried in ash and cool lava. Her eyes widened, then.

“...What is this place?” She asks again, now even more confused.

"Answer my question, and I'll tell you." He says simply. "Why are you here?"

"Revenge." She supplies, huffing. "That's why I'm here. Revenge."

"Revenge shouldn't ever be your only motivation for things, little sister," He shakes his head disappointedly. "Do you know why?"

"No," She bites. "And quite frankly, I don't care. What is thus place?!"

He ignores her question. "Ghosts are formed when they cannot rest in peace; ghosts have unfinished business in the mortal plane." He began to explain, walking next to C'yra and seemingly looking over the ruined city. "When a ghost accomplishes its final goal, the ghost reaches the other side- where you were. They either reincarnate or…. they go to the bad place. Do tou understand what I'm trying to tell you?"

She stays silent out of spite. She sees him smile again, small but blood curdling all the same.

"Little sister, when you enact your revenge, your soul will be at peace-"

"I pray to never rest in peace."

Shanyuan barks out a laugh- the most emotion she thinks she's seen from him. "Good," he comments idly. "Think of a new reason. You have time to make up your mind."

They're both silent for a moment, peaceful in a war zone. She breaks the silence, "Will you answer my question now?"

She thinks he glances at her then. "This was the old Horde Prime Kingdom." He answers. "Destroyed, obviously."

"Is that it?" She asks, trying to get more information out of him. "What else? This is your home, after all, can't you tell me more?"

He looks at her, a towering, all powerful presence. She would never admit that she's scared of what he could do to her.

"If you're smart enough, and you get where you're supposed to," He says slowly. "The Kingdom will tell its story to you."

Then, before she can ask anything else, "Can you read, little sister?"

"Yes," She replies. "I can read."

He nods, and she looks back over the vast city.

"What about you-" She begins to ask, only to turn towards where Shanyuan stood…. and was met with the sight of a cat, completely white in color with bright green eyes.

She reaches for it, curious. Upon touching it, the cat dissipates like ash, white and shiny all around her.

So, she had her mission: find out the history of the kingdom.

She figured that only when she dissected it's history, would she be able to enter the kiln.

And she would do whatever it took to enter the kiln.

Chapter End Notes

sooo... I got broken up with at 2:14 am over text, so I channeled all my rage and hatred into writing for this series lol... if you're wondering, yes I promise I'm fine.
Anyways, I've been backed up with writing because of stress from school, but I'm trying to be better! Chapter 3 is shaping up to be the longest chapter of this, so it make take me more time to write, for which I apologize for!!!

anyways, if this is formatted weird it's cause I uploaded it from my phone lol!!! please let me know if you liked this chapter by commenting or leaving a kudos if you haven't already. I love you all, thank you for sticking with me, and ill see you in the next chapter my loves <33

i can't be your savior

Chapter Summary

> The girl who stares back at her- well, she isn't quite a girl anymore. More of a woman, now. Regardless, the woman who stares back at her is not one she recognizes.

Chapter Notes

> Trigger warning for: a lot of gore. like a lot.
>
> Title comes from "reckless driving" by Lizzy McAlpine! I hope you enjoy this chapter <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"What do you think she looks like?" Catra asks. Adora's cheeks turn a light pink as she looks down at her hands- definitely not what Catra expected.

"Well… She's a Ghost King, so she must have many different forms.." She says. "But I'm sure her original form is of a young woman, not much older than you. She's…. probably attractive, too."

"You can't be too sure, you know." Catra responds plainly, then points to her left eye. "But, she's blind in one eye. She dug it out herself."

Adora looks mildly concerned at that, and Catra swears she sees her face turn a little green. "How… how come?" She asks, her voice wavering slightly.

What a question Adora had asked. Why had Catra done that? She could give Adora the long answer, but the long answer was too long. So, instead she settled on giving Adora the short answer:

"...She went crazy."

—

She spends the next two hours walking around the kingdom, dissecting its language. It was different, but not much different from that of the Fright Kingdom's.

The Prime Kingdom, she figures out. Just like the Fright Kingdom, they worshiped their Crown Prince who… was born under a cursed star. The very same cursed star that she and Adora were born under.

A handsome Prince, she'll give the Prime Kingdom that. Handsome, and from what she could tell from the painted walls- mostly covered in soot -he was quite savvy with his hands.

(While exploring, she encountered an animal- a grey cat that had slight discoloration to it- yet the discolored parts were blue, rather than white. It was odd, but it was even odder when the cat began to follow her around. She just accepted the fact that she now had a companion.)

She stops before one temple, one called “The Temple of the Sun” from what she can tell, contemplating on if she should enter it or not. Her decision is cut short by the rumble of battle far in the distance- and she decides that no, she needs to keep moving forwards.

Most of the information that she’s found out about the Prime Kingdom came from within those temples- painted on the walls, murals of sorts, of the Crown Prince. Not once, however, had she ever found his name- all she could find was his title, “The Sun Prince”.

Regardless, she’s sure whatever was in that temple would not be anything new- a lot of the temples had repeating stories, just told differently.

She found early on that a lot of the mountains moved- rolled over hordes of ghosts, crushing them -but they never once toppled over the mountain in the very middle: the true Mount Tong’lu, in which lay the Kiln.

Battles become quicker in succession the closer she moves to the kiln, fiercer. More blood is shed and she finds herself gaining more strength with each ghost she kills. She’s powerful, but she needs *more.*

She, unfortunately even as a ghost, has limitations. She’s forced to feed on weaker ghosts, as she can’t take on the higher ranking- savage ranked -ghosts with sheer strength and power alone. She needs a weapon, a good one, to properly face them but- every

weapon she comes across (all low-leveled ones) have a habit of shattering in her hands when she tries to use them.

She can't figure out a way to create the kind of weapon she desires. She's smart, she knows that, but she just can't seem to figure it out-

She's made it to the foot of *the* mountain, then, when she feels the cat butt it's head against her leg, trying to alert her of something. Then, she feels it- feels that something is… out of place. Very out of place. She can feel it in the air, and when she inhales- she smells it. *Humans.*

She scowls and looks around, unsure where these humans even are. Why were there humans in a demonic breeding ground? How did they even get in? What was the purpose of it? Was this a trick from another ghost- a much stronger one, that can fake scents to entice other ghosts?

Trick or not, it explains why a lot of the weaker ghosts were flocking to this area. It's a great tactic, if it is a trick.

She blinks, and suddenly there was a leg dangling in front of her, perched on a higher rock on the mountain. A black boot connected to a body in white robes- not mourning robes, but close enough to them.

“Why, look at you,” The voice drawls from above. “You could make a smart decision here, little sister.”

She looks up and revels in the sight of Shanyuan. She grimaces at him and glances away. “What the fuck is that supposed to mean?” She spits out. He doesn’t seem to be annoyed by her sass, this time.

“Little sister, you know what you need for the kiln… don’t you?” Shanyuan asks, his tone rather condescending- but a lot of what he says sounds like that, so she pays no mind.

She rolls her eyes, though, and starts to move past him- only for the leg he has dangling over the edge to stop her. He uses the tip of his boot to dig into her chest and push her backwards at least two feet.

“You need a spiritual tool,” He continues on, as if nothing happened. He was looking- if you could even call it that, with the bandage like cloth over his eyes -everywhere but her. “And right now, you aren’t armed to do much more than please a man.”

She didn’t think she could glare at the robotic-like man any harder, but her time here continues to prove her and her previous beliefs wrong. He raises an arm in surrender, as if to say *‘no offense!’* and says, “..Or a woman, if you swing that way.”

She wanted nothing more than to lunge at him and rip out his throat with her claws- which have seemingly become a permanent fixture of her ghostly appearance.

"Astute observation, Guoshi Shanyuan, I'll make sure to pick up a spiritual weapon the next time I stop at the town fair!" She responds, slightly growling.

"What an attitude, little sister," Shanyuan feigns shock and horror. His face falls, and becomes much like the expressionless statues she had seen in the temples. "If you dropped the attitude for a little bit and stopped being such a- for lack of a better word -little shit, I can teach you something, hm? How does that sound, *C'yra?"*

It feels odd to her, to be able to finally answer to that name. She went decades not being able to even answer to it, only to suddenly be able to within the confines of this place.

Shanyuan takes her silence as obedience.

"Spiritual tools are *always* formed from blood sacrifices," He explains, looking just over her head and somewhere into the distance, she thinks. "If you're smart enough, little sister…"

He turns his head towards a cave opening just a few feet from them in the mountain- one she hadn't even seen -that reeks of humans, "...You'll have a powerful forge."

She glances towards the cave then towards Shanyuan, who had a sickening smile on his pale face. “No,” She says. “Spiritual tools, they’re made from heroic acts, aren’t they? Martyrdom, enduring suffering, things like that.”

Shanyuan huffs a laugh at that, shaking his head. “Who teaches things like that? The gods?” He sighs dramatically. “What do they know, Eternia and their gods? Nothing!”

“What are you saying?” She asks, now genuinely confused. She had always been taught- even in the Fright Kingdom, as fucked up as it was, that spiritual tools came from noble acts.

Shanyuan leans forwards, leaning his chin in his hand, seemingly staring into C’yra’s soul through the bandages. “Listen to me, little sister, and listen well,” He whispers. “Magic; it doesn’t care how kind of a person, how good or how evil of a person you are. It only cares about how much you pay for it- it’s a transaction, not some kind of moral dilemma.”

“And the price?” She prods, knowing full well the answer- he had already said it.

“Blood,” He answers. “The price is blood. The more you give, the more you get. It’s as easy as that.”

"...How do you know so much about these things?" C'yra asks then, and she knows how invasive of a question it is, but she can't help it. She watches as Shanyuan's face slightly falls, and she swears that whatever emotion that crosses it is bitterness.

He looks away, back towards the cave. "I've forged my fair share of spiritual tools in my lifetime."

She follows his gaze to the cave, and she knows what he wants her to do.

"While I don't agree with your current reason to stay in this world," Shanyuan pipes up. "If you want to enact revenge… you need to be able to make these kinds of decisions. Life- and the afterlife -is not fair, and will never be fair."

"Yeah, I'm deathly aware of that fact." She responds, glancing up at him, her face set with determination.

He smirks at her as he watches her stalk towards the cave, because he knows what will come next- the human's demise, or her's.

It takes people a lifetime to even begin to hate their own species- but it was never like that for C'yra. She hated humans since she was small, her only exception being Adora. Adora was her exception to everything- she hated all forms of royalty *except* for Adora, hated all humans except for Adora… and there was a time

where C'yra believed she'd hate all the gods except for Adora, as well.

But no, she hates Adora too. Adora is no longer her exception, and will never be her exception ever again. As it turns out, time doesn't heal any wounds- it only makes them deeper.

She was fully prepared to take up Shanyuan's suggestion when she reached the mouth of the cave and looked inwards- and suddenly, it changed everything. This was not something she had expected, *ever.*

"....Miss?" the voice calls, soft, frightened and *young.* She freezes, then slowly inches further into the cave. Her eyes adjust rather slowly to the lighting, and she finds that… there's only one adult in the cave, surrounded by at least a dozen young children.

The only adult in the room, a girl, is sitting in the furthest corner of the cave, cradling an infant in her arms.

C'yra was terribly confused at this whole situation, and her voice reflected that,

"...What is it?"

The girl looks up at the sound of her voice and yelps- and, well, C'yra supposes that she doesn't exactly look the most welcoming.

The girl cringes and tries to push herself further against the wall of the cave, terrified and trying to protect the children around her.

"Why are you… here?" She asks now, regaining some of her composure. The girl looked absolutely terrified, and unsure if she should respond but after C'yra glared a bit, the girl began to speak.

"We… we had b-been traveling s-since there…. There wasn't enough room at the orphanage in B-Brightmoon," She stutters. "A-Another traveling m-merchant said he-he had a place for u-us, so…"

C'yra… finds herself feeling bad. The girl couldn't be any older than 18, and she was naive, and she was trying to find these kids a shelter. The girl was still a fool, but a fool who had good intentions. She steps into the light to try and make her form less intimidating- and also to show off the cat in a way to make herself seem friendlier.

She looks around, taking in the spider-webbed walls covered in blood, and the occasional bat. She nodded slowly before looking back at the girl. "Well, It's certainly an interesting place to set up an… orphanage, I'll give him that." She tries to joke. One of the kids laughs, startled and still scared, only causing the girl to glare at the child- probably in an attempt to keep the child quiet, thinking anything could provoke C'yra.

“It wasn’t supposed to be h-here!” The girl argues. “H-he… he kept saying how there were too many demons on the r-road, so he tried to hire a priest but…. It didn’t w-work! So he said the b-best thing was to hide.”

The girl looks broken as she glances up at C’yra, “There were twice as many of us before.” She says, voice cracking and eyes welling up with tears.

It’s like a punch to C’yra’s gut. She didn’t think it was possible for her to feel any sympathy for humans, yet here she is.

“Where’s the priest?” She asks, because there was definitely something odd about this situation- and she has an inkling as to what the truth of the matter is.

“L-left hours ago to g-get help,” The girl responds weakly. “He never came back…”

She turns back around and inspects the cave opening- and she sees it now, the rune drawn in blood.

It makes sense, now- confirms her thoughts. A priest, most likely of the demonic kind, trying to capitalize on all the resentment that would come from the opening of Tong’lu. Except, it’s now half effective, because he did a poor job of keeping all of his sacrifices alive.

This is the exact reason why she hates humans. Inhumane, cruel, trying to capitalize on resentment by sacrificing innocent souls. It's terrible- but, then again, C'yra can't speak when she's trying to do the exact same thing. The only difference is that she isn't sacrificing innocent children.

"Did you come to save us?" One of the little children- a boy, she thinks -asks from beside the girl. When C'yra doesn't respond, she thinks she sees the boy point towards the cave door and add, "There's ghosts out there."

She stares down at the child, then at the rest of them, expression unreadable.

As much as she wished, she was really not that far removed from her mortal life. Especially within Tong'lu, she was still… C'yra.

Growing up, she didn't have much. Not until Adora showed up, saved her from her place on the street and gave her a sense of purpose in life. And Adora, she was so good, so kind. The only kind person that C'yra had even encountered in her entire life. Even now, after everything that she's been through, she can still say Adora is the kindest person she's known. She is flawed, and she's selfish and C'yra *hates* her, but she can admit that she's kind.

Adora had been her inspiration, had been the person she looked up to. A lot of situations in her life, when she was at a crossroads,

she had a habit of thinking, if Adora was in that situation, what would she do?

She looks at the child hard, sees the hope and naivety in his eyes. She was once like that, young and naive, hopeful. The real world wrecked her, killing all hope she had ever held. She could do what Shanyuan had implied- she's sure that a sacrifice of such caliber would create a weapon of pure evil, enough to take her to the kiln immediately. She could be cruel, and she could leave the children here too. She's capable of the former, and is almost inclined to do the latter but….

Old habits die hard.

"...I'll try." She tells them. It's fine, she tells herself. She'll fight tooth and nail to keep this kids safe, even without a spiritual tool or device. She has her claws, and if the worst comes to worst, she has her teeth. She won't resort to the original plan.

And really, it can't be that bad. All the ghosts she fought on the way here were low ranking, not that powerful. They were lowlifes, and the more she defeats the more strength she gains. This could be a good thing- could benefit her, in the end.

"Thank you," The girl says, her voice breaking. C'yra says nothing in return, just turns on her heel and begins to walk out of the cave, determined.

She feels Shanyuan’s eyes following her as she walks out of the cave. She doesn’t look at him as a silent move of defiance.

“What are you doing?” He asks, his tone genuinely curious.

“Something stupid.” C’yra responds. She sees him nod out of the corner of her eye.

“Good,” He comments. “You’re self aware at least.”

And he watches her, curiously. He knows how this is going to end, one way or another, but still- he watches her try.

For 4 days, she tries.

She slaughters hordes of ghosts, goblins, demons- the whole bunch. She slaughters so many that the piles become mounds on the mountain path.

She tries until she’s soaked in blood up to her elbows, to the point where her claws are so slick with blood that she has to resort to using her teeth. She ends up looking more like a beast than a hero protecting the innocent.

She stumbles back into the cave on the fourth day, attempting to wipe the sweat off her forehead with her blood soaked arm, only leaving her forehead streaking with blood. There's a stream in the back of the cave from one of the many aqueducts of the Prime Kingdom. Most of the water now is corpse water, and she already had wasted a great deal of spiritual power on purifying the water enough for herself and the humans to drink.

She stumbles towards the stream, exhausted and barely able to walk straight, and begins to try and clean herself up. She was shaking erratically, barely able to clean herself properly. She tries scrubbing her arms, pouring the water over her face to try and clean it. She tries to dig underneath her claws with the water, to see if it makes them any sharper. None of her efforts do much, really.

She didn't notice the teenage girl walking closer to her until she felt a cold hand against her cheek, rubbing slightly. She was startled, and in the shock she snapped her head towards her, whatever sound leaving her mouth a mix between a hiss and a growl.

The girl recoils, falls back slightly with the reaction. "I-I'm sorry, miss!" She exclaims, her eyes becoming glassy and almost fearful. The girl is sat there, trembling. The other children trust her, or at least aren't scared of her- they see her as a friend, actually, yet the girl… was still scared of her.

"What are you doing?" She asks, her voice foreign to her own ears- she isn't used to hearing her voice so hoarse and gruff.

“I… I was t-trying to help,” The girl stutters out. “You’re… you’re shaking.”

“So?” C’yra bites out half-heartedly. “You are too.”

“..Let me h-help,” The girl offers, inching closer to her. C’yra just now registers the rag in the girl’s hand- she didn’t even realize she had one. C’yra makes no effort to move- too exhausted and drained to do much else but let the girl do as she wanted. Her touch was gentle, her movements careful as the girl began to wipe down her face. The girl was still scared, yet she was still able to touch her so carefully, so gently…. The last time she had ever been touched in such a manner was-

“I…. uhm, I’m really… s-sorry,” The girl says, wringing the rag out over the stream before dunking it back in to wet it to begin cleaning up her arms. “For screaming the way I did, b-before.”

She could hear the emotions in the girl's voice- shame, regret, guilt. C’yra didn’t say anything.

“I-I’ve always been afraid of ghosts,” The girl whispers. “I just.. D-didn’t know there were good ones.”

The rest of the time she spends cleaning her up, they’re silent.

The girl is halfway through cleaning the last claw on her left hand when C'yra stiffens, back on alert after nearly dozing off. Her eyes dart around the cave before she begins to stand up.

"There's more coming." She explains to the girl. The girl looks up at her, scared but grateful nonetheless. She holds her gaze for a second, not sure if she should say anything else to her. She feels her gaze soften, her shoulders sag and she adds, "...Thank you." very quietly.

She doesn't stick around to hear the girl's reply, instead stalking out of the cave and throwing herself into battle after battle, taking out any and all pent up rage she has. She pretends each ghost horde she fights is a different incarnation of Adora, and she slaughters each one as brutally as she can. She finds it doesn't soothe her rage- it fans the flames of the rage. It makes it stronger, makes her hate Adora even more.

She thins out the weaker hordes of ghosts a bunch, and now she sees what waits for her just beyond the next group- a powerful, savage ranked ghost.

The thing is a beast, at least 9 feet tall or more. She sees it wields a whip, dripping in blood.

She doesn't flinch, doesn't cower. She calculates her odds at beating it- low, but her chances are never zero.

She lunges forward, defeats the horde in front of her in record time, then falls back to continue strategizing. She doesn't think the beast has seen her yet- at least, she hopes not. She's sure though that if it did, it would've jumped at the chance to fight her.

"What are you doing?" Shanyuan calls once she makes up her mind and begins to advance towards the beast. Shanyuan watches as she drops into a crawl, practically blending in with the ground.

"Something…" she huffs, breathing heavily. "Stupid!"

Shanyuan watches as the ghost hopelessly fights with the beast. She's incredibly determined, he'll give her that, but she's no match for that beast.

He's impressed when she manages to injure the beast, and he continues to watch as she climbs on the beast's shoulders and begins to claw out its eyes… but he's filled with dread- an emotion he didn't even think was possible for him to feel -as the beast raises its whip.

And she's no match for that whip, a powerful spiritual tool, the very thing he had been insisting she needed from the beginning.

The whip makes contact with her, completely slicing open her back and leaving her disoriented on the ground. She cries out and

frustration, and somehow the hit doesn't loosen her determination- no, it makes her have a new found bloodlust. She gets up and continues to fight the beast, even as blood pours out of her back.

"Little sister, little sister!" Shanyuan calls, genuinely *distressed.* "You have to stop! This is a fool's mission, you can't take another hit!"

"They'll die if I do!" C'yra shouts back, and Shanyuan damns the girl for being so determined. Her soul is strong, he can see that now. He didn't think it at first, but he sees it now. She's stubbornly strong, but she's a fool.

"And if you die, they'll die too, little sister," He continues, rising to his feet in frustration. "What is the point in that!?"

C'yra knows that, she knows it too well. She refuses to accept it, refuses to accept that she either uses those kids to her own advantage or dies trying to save them.

"There is no third path, little sister," Shanyuan exclaims, tone condescending. "You know what you have to do!"

"Shut up you ogre!" She screams, still trying to fight the beast. "You don't think I already know that!?"

"Ogre!?" Shanyuan yells back. "Who are you calling an *ogre* you useless-"

She screams to drown out his voice, but she's exhausted. She knows he's right.

"Stop being a coward!" He roars. "Just do it already!"

She groans in frustration and jumps back, all the way to the top of the cave opening. He's right, and she hates it.

She sees another spirit coming at them- an earth spirit of some kind. She knows that neither will attack her, thankfully- they'll fight each other to see which gets to finish her off.

She finally has a moment to catch her breath and to really feel the pain. It's minimal, but she attributes that to the adrenaline in her veins. Her breathing is ragged as she tries to wipe the blood off of her arms and hands to no avail.

It's hopeless, a lost cause, this whole thing. She looks down into the mouth of the cave- and she tried. She tried so hard, and still, her hardest wasn't good enough. Again.

Her hardest would never be good enough, she thinks. She knows that those kids, they don't deserve to die- but she isn't willing to die for them. That isn't who she is. She knows what it feels like to

die for people, and it’s never freeing. It felt good, yes, that she was able to die to protect someone else, but she hates her. She hates who she died for.

It’s a transaction, runs through her mind, a mile a minute. Transaction, a transaction, the price is the sacrifice of blood. The more you give, the more you get.

She doesn’t have to kill all of them, no, one is enough. Only one has to die. She thinks she can live with that.

She drops down into the cave, and she thinks she's made up her mind. It doesn’t have to be one of the children- it can be the girl. The girl who foolishly led them into that situation in the first place.

She.. she can kill the girl as her offering, and just add more souls to it later if she wasn’t enough. That’s all. It may not be fair- certainly not to the girl -but then again, when has life ever been fair to her?

She sees them now, cowering in the corner. The girl is trying to keep the children from crying too loud.

She knows what she has to do- there is no third path, no third door like there was before. She dies or they die.

Her fingers extend into talons, continuing to walk further. Life is not fair, has never been fair to her and never will be. She is a monster, a failure- and this proves that. She has become what they all said she was.

“Miss?”

She halts, feeling the bottom of her robes being tugged by one of the children. She slowly turns her head to look at the child, covered in sweat, grime and blood. She says nothing.

“Did the ghosts hurt you?” The child asks, naive as ever. She feels stuck, like she can’t move or speak.

“Don’t go back out there, miss!” One of the other children yells, running up to her and grabbing her hand, not minding the claws or the dirt. “We can find another way out!”

“Yeah!” Another child chimes. “If we’re really quiet, we can get away from the ghosts!”

None of it will matter, and she supposes the kids are too young to realize that. She used to be like that, eyes wide with wonder and trusting.

She looks up at the girl- the girl who a few moments earlier, she had justified in slaughtering and… the girl, she's smiling at her,

holding as many of the kids close to her as she can.

The girl knows. She's probably the only other one in the room who knows- this is it. This is the end.

The girl mouths the same words C'yra had said to her earlier: *'Thank you'.*

She hears the monster outside roar, and she knows she doesn't have much time.

Old habits die hard. If this was Adora, she would've died already. Adora would've died fighting those monsters, because Adora loves the world and Adora loves the people. Adora always tries to find the third path- the third path that never exists.

C'yra doesn't love people, and she doesn't love the world, and she knows that the third path doesn't exist. She and Adora will never be the same person, and she's grateful- They don't need to be the same person.

"Miss?" The child calls, confused when she begins to pull away. "Don't go back out there, it's not sa-"

He's cut off by a taloned, dirty hand patting his head. "Don't be afraid," She says lowly. It's the only reassurance she offers as she walks slowly towards the cave entrance.

She watches two incredibly strong spirits battle it out.

This isn't salvation, this isn't to prove to everyone that she isn't what they say she is. The truth is- she is everything she's ever been called. She's a monster, she's hideous, a failure.

But, she's also a knight, who at one point was noble. She certainly fought for a noble cause- her Princess.

If anything, she does this to prove that she *is* all of those things- a monster, a failure, a knight fallen from grace.

Her hand lifts and grazes the eyelid of her left eye- her cursed eye. She traces the sharp claw over it, contemplating if she is really about to do this.

…but then again, she never was a villain, was she? Maybe to Adora and her new friends, then yes, she was the villain, but within her own life. She wasn't a villain, more like a… anti-hero.

She's fine with that title: The Anti-hero.

"Little sister…" Shanyuan calls. "What are you doing?"

She stops tracing her eyelid, instead staying in a solid position. She smiles, fangs bared and blood dripping out from in between the cracks. Shanyuan understands, he knows now.

"Something…"

Her fingers dig in, pressing in around her own eye- her cursed eye. The eye that had brought her nothing but bad luck in her life, cause that's what a curse is. Bad luck.

This eye made her an outcast, and it she's sort of banking on this feeling cathartic by reclaiming it in such a way. Her eye, the thing that cursed her since the day she was born, the reason of her death- will be the thing to save her. *That* was her salvation.

"Stupid!"

To gauge out one's eye is no small feat- even if you're accustomed to pain, the pain that brings with ripping out your eye is not something you can be prepared for.

The roar that rips itself out of her chest is, well, legendary- it rumbles all around her, bringing the two ghosts ahead of her to a stop. They look on in confusion, then horror when they see what she's done.

The pain- it’s searing, pure agony. Her eye socket pulses and burns, she can feel it all the way in her feet. But this, this pain and her eye- it’s enough. More than enough. It’s a high price to pay for the transactional magic that is required to create a spiritual tool.

She screams again, the pain too much- and this scream is louder than the last. She drops to her knees, eye in one hand while the other holds her face. She looks up at the sky, now only seeing the world through one eye. She laughs erratically, letting her hand that holds her face to drop. The sky was a murky gray, though she could see it beginning to turn red- a signifier of the red sky eclipse.

She breathes heavily and looks back down at the eye. She closes her fist over the eye, “Come…” She whispers, sounding absolutely insane. “Come to me!”

She lifts her hand up- and she watches as a blade forms itself around her sacrifice. The handle molds perfectly around her fingers, watches as the silver blade takes form- a Scimitar. She couldn’t be more thrilled.

“Little sister!” Shanyuan yells, sounding… impressed. “Why, I- I can’t… I can’t tell if you're the bravest soul I’ve ever met, or… the most foolish.”

She brings the blade down- see’s the word “melog” engraved on the handle -and smiles. She has half a mind to register that her smile probably looks similar to Shanyuan’s bone chilling smiles.

“How about you fuckin’ find out?”

After that, it isn’t a fight anymore. Not a battle- it’s just slaughtering. Pure, unbridled slaughtering.

The blade shrieks much like its master did upon creating it, and it takes her less than 20 minutes to defeat two of the most powerful spirits on the field. Melog, truly, was like a calamity.

She stands over the two ghost’s bodies, head tilted back, laughing hysterically. She distantly registers something falling on her- rain, she thinks. She revels in it, arms thrown out at her side and allows the rain to wash her over.

Only when she opens her eye…. She realizes it’s raining *blood.*

A baptism of blood.

She laughs harder at this fact, letting her arms drop at her side. She brings one hand up and smears the blood rain all over her face, heaving from over exertion.

When she finally stops, really takes it in… she realizes very quickly that yes, this is truly a baptism.

Golden light washed over her, followed by a-

BANG!

"...What a cheat," She hears Shanyuan mutter, which in all honesty just confuses her because-

The pain that consumed her body is gone. The sky is blue, there are no trails of ash or blood or anything.

The road ahead of her is made of pristine brick, white in color and perfectly placed. She looks around- palaces everywhere she looks.

She knows where she is. She knows it well.

She looks ahead of her- and in front of her stands a man, who looks to be about in his mid 40s, handsome and tall. Striking resemblance to Adora.

He extends his hand to the ghost- or, well, *god* to shake her hand. He smiles.

“Welcome, friend.”

And it hits her then- this man, he’s the heavenly emperor… Randor…

She doesn’t take his hand, just stares at him in shock, horror, hate.

“Yes, yes, welcome rookie god to Eternia- there are logistics we need to handle..” A voice echoes from behind Randor.

The voice turns out to be the civil goddess, Angella, who holds a clipboard in her hand. She’s staring down at that clipboard, now that C’yra focuses her eye on her.

“Now…” Angella trails off, taping her pen on the clipboard. “Is she going to be a civil goddess or martial? She ascended while in battle, but it was much like how Perfuma ascended…”

“Oh, lighten up Angella,” Randor replies good naturedly. C’yra watches the two, a little lost and confused at what exactly was going on.

“We’re short a martial god, Randor.” Angella says, then does not add on to see what the Emperor’s input is.

“How about we make her the Fire Master?” Randor asks. “We haven’t had one since… gods, decades ago.”

“Hm… yes, yes,” Angella murmurs, scribbling something down on the clipboard. “We could make that work-”

“No need to make anything work.” C’yra cuts in quickly.

“No need?! There absolutely is a need, young lady!” Angella exclaims, offended at the mere idea of C’yra saying that there was *‘no need’.*

“No, I mean like,” She trails off, then waves her hands around. “I’m staying. As a civil goddess, martial or your.. Fire master.”

Randor furrows his brows at her. “You think that that decision is yours to make?”

….Old habits die hard.

She looks around, at all the gods who stood at a distance, watching as a new god was seemingly coronated in Eternia. C’yra had no interest in becoming a goddess- because she wanted to be nothing like Adora. Wanted no part in whatever she was in.

Eternia had continued to fail her, and she was never going to join a system that was flawed so deeply.

She looks down- down at Etheria.

“Every decision of mine is mine to make,” She answers. “And even if they weren’t, they would never be yours to make, either.”

Marlena- who just arrived -gasps rather dramatically. “That’s the Emperor!” She exclaims, horrified. “Who do you think you’re talking to?!”

C’yra simply shrugs, backing up towards the edge of Eternia. “I’ve never prayed to him, and never will,” She reasons. “Eternian Emperor or common farmer, it makes no difference to me, Your Majesty.”

She tries to say the title with as much contempt as she can muster. She smiles, showing off the fangs she had adopted as a weapon in Mount Tong’lu.

“If you aren’t staying here,” Randor begins. “What are you going to do, then?”

She laughs. “You killed the only Ghost King, Your Majesty,” She drawls. “...There must be another.”

(Old habits die hard.)

The Eternian Gates behind her open, and what feels like the entirety of Eternia watches as a newly ascended god casts themselves back to the mortal realm- for the second time in 90 years.

C'yra casts herself back down, like a bloody shooting star, collides with the ground beneath her in Mount Tong'lu- eradicating whatever ghost hordes that were fighting in a ten mile radius upon her impact.

"Oh, little sister, you're back," Shanyuan drawls from behind her. "I didn't think you would."

"Oh, of course I did," She responds. "Why would I ever want to stay with the gods?"

"Fair point. How was it up there?"

"Stuffy."

Shanyuan snorts.

C’yra smiles, and for the first time since entering Mount Tong’lu, she looks at herself. She raises Melog to see her reflection in the blade.

The girl who stares back at her- well, she isn’t quite a girl anymore. More of a woman, now. Regardless, the woman who stares back at her is not one she recognizes.

She stares at a woman who’s gone to hell and back; She stares at a woman who has gone mad.

A mad woman who had done the impossible- looked the Emperor in the face and told him no.

A mad woman, who has forged a third path for herself.

Chapter End Notes

> andddddddddd thats the chapter folks, I hope you enjoyed it! I'd love to know your thoughts on this one hehe... we're in the homestretch of this fanfic, I hope you're all excited to read the rest, because I'm really excited to write it lol!!!!!
> I just want to add that, if you didn't pick up on it, every time Catra (C'yra, of course) said "old habits die hard" it was supposed to signify her thinking of what Adora would do in each situation it was mentioned. Just wanted to clarify that, if it was confusing or anything. I also forgot to mention this in chapter 2 but: "Shanyuan" means Mountain Source, so if you want to infer what that means in regards to the rest of the fic... i'd love to hear about it lol.

Anyways, I hope you all enjoyed this! Don't forget to comment your thoughts, I love to hear them and they keep me motivated to keep writing!!!!!! See you in the next one, folks!!

(P.S: The beginning section, the part entirely in italics, was an excerpt taken directly from "when you're gone, it's forever"!!!)

there's something in the static, i think i've been having revelations

Chapter Summary

Three savage ghosts remain.

And then there's two.

And now, there's one.

Chapter Notes

title of the chapter comes from "Not Strong Enough" by boygenius!!

TW for: gore, blood, graphic language (i'm positively sure that thats it?)

good luck, and I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

C'yra's battles in her mortal life- and even afterlife -have always been quick affairs. She was a seamless fighter, always agile and smart with her well positioned strikes. She supposes that's why she was Adora's knight, after all- she was good at her job, and Shadow Weaver had always made sure of that fact.

Fights within Mount Tong'lu were anything but swift.

4 years, it's been. 4 years. Time moves slowly, and the fights even slower.

Three savage rank ghosts remain:

A sword spirit by the name of Adonis. The spirit lurks over mountain tops, shrieking and enticing any foolish ghost in the area to come to him, just for him to strike them down.

A ghost wrapped in bandages, who has no known name. It lurks within the forest of Mount Tong'lu, scaring any and all ghosts off with his roar- and those foolish enough to stay are quickly dealt with.

A ghost with one eye and maple red robes, nameless outside of the field but within it goes by C'yra. She has gained many names over those 4 years spent within her catacomb- The Cave Dweller, The Mountain Demon, Blood-robed demon.

She's seen the least- lurking in her caverns beneath the very mountain in which the other ghosts roam. She's had no interest in leaving her dwelling, either. It gives her a false sense of security- in an environment as dangerous as Tong'lu, this has been her small reprieve. Four years of relative peace.

Well, that's if you could count "peace" as constantly being on alert, mistaking your own footsteps as an attacker.

Somewhere along the way, C'yra had begun to change. She had begun to see in the dark- clearly, not even the slightly obstructed

view like most people. She was able to see in the dark like she was able to see with light.

Her hearing got better- at first, she thought it was because of how paranoid she had become, but no, even when her guard was down, she was able to hear every little thing within her caverns. Her smell, too- her smell had never been that strong, even as a ghost. It was a shock to her when she breathed in once and the smells around her were so… pungent.

Eventually, she couldn't even recognize the sound of her own footsteps (which of course contributed to her ever growing paranoia). She found she had grown out of her boots- she didn't even know that was possible -and was forced to walk barefoot around the caverns. Her footsteps used to sound like, well, skin hitting against rock- and somewhere along the way, they began to sound like claws dragging along concrete.

She wasn't sure what any of these changes were, or how they came about, but she just figured it was going to benefit her in the end. Hopefully.

She's relatively alone down there, as much as she doesn't believe it. It's just her, and that cat that follows her around. She started to call it Melog after she found it resting next to the scimitar- shocking, truly. She didn't think any living thing would dare touch the abomination that was her scimitar.

Shanyuan pops in, sometimes. She's not sure how he comes and goes undetected, but he always visits at the worst times

imaginable.

"Don't you find it cold down here, little sister?" He asks one time, almost mockingly, as he watches her heave a boulder towards the middle of one of the caverns.

"No, not really," She huffs, finally determining it to be adequate enough. "It was cold for a while in the beginning, but it… got warm, over time."

"And you don't find that odd?" Shanyuan pokes. "The fact that you… just got warm? And haven't felt cold since?"

"No, not really." She repeats, inspecting the piece of rock in front of her. She had a vision- she just wasn't sure if she could execute it correctly. She had taken up sculpting- and, if the situation provided (if she had enough blood) she'd paint murals on the walls. It was one of the only calming things within Tong'lu that she could do comfortably. She's never been artsy, but she found herself to be quite talented in the facet of painting, and sculpting. "It's normal to grow accustomed to your conditions after a while."

"Yes! Exactly!" Shanyuan explains exasperatedly. "That's exactly what I'm trying to say! Do you not question any of the differences in yourself?"

She pauses. "What are you trying to say?" She asks slowly.

“To look in a mirror every once in a while.” Shanyuan responds, completely deadpan. “It’s beneficial, I promise.”

“What do you know!?” She roars, turning to face him on his ledge in the cave. “You can’t even see!”

Her words reverberate around the mostly empty cave, bounces off the walls. Her own voice haunts her. Shanyuan doesn’t respond; he opts to laugh, not hysterically but close enough.

“Little sister, I see everything.” He says when he stops laughing. “You fail to realize that only when you become blind… you truly see.”

“What is that even supposed to mean?!” She yells, confused out of her mind, frustrated and *angry.*

This time, he doesn’t answer at all. Just laughs, and when he deems his taunting to be enough, explodes into those cat-like apparitions that she’s begun to associate him with.

His laugh haunts her. Plays in her mind on repeat, it causes her to pace. When she isn’t pacing, she’s busying her hands- sculpting, painting. The subject of her endeavors are always the same: Always Adora, trying to perfect her likeness. She tries to tell

herself it's so she can destroy it when she's done, but she refuses to destroy any of her failed attempts.

She has a feeling that she won't destroy the perfect attempts either.

One time, Shanyuan appears to her when she's sculpting the Adora from just before she left the Fright Kingdom.

"Do you know what they say of you, little sister?" Shanyuan questions after watching her methodically sculpt out the girl's face. "Oh, how they mock you. They call you all sorts of names- mad, insane, deranged…"

C'yra has counted how many sculptures she's made of Adora. This is the nine hundred and fiftieth attempt at sculpting her. The features staring back at her- they are defined, but soft and gentle in the way that Adora was back then. They are kind, welcoming, but they do not do justice to Adora.

"Do you think the same?" C'yra questions, dissatisfied with her work but not one to abandon ship. "Do you think I'm all of those things?"

"Yes," Shanyuan replies quickly. "But not in the way that they think."

She doesn’t know what he means by that. But, most of the things he says to her go over her head most of the time. A small price she has to pay for keeping him around.

“Have you thought of a new reason to live on, yet?” He questions. She can hear the sound of his robes rustling- she supposes he’s swinging his feet back and forth. Like a child.

“No,” She responds quickly, beginning to carve harsher lines into the sculpture at the reminder. “I told you, that’s the only reason. There will be no other reason. Ever.”

Shanyuan sighs dramatically and simply mutters, “Dig two graves, little sister.”

It’s quiet after that, so quiet that C’yra thinks he’s done his disappearing act and is gone for the next few weeks- only to be sorely surprised when he speaks up.

“I’ve seen you painting and sculpting this girl for years now,” He begins. “Who is she?”

C’yra’s learned to separate the Adora who left her from the Adora who had been with her since her childhood- from the Adora she had seen just before her second death. Those Adora’s… they’re two separate people in her head, now. She chooses to remember the Adora who stayed with her, and only remembers the Adora who left her when she spirals.

"..My Princess." C'yra responds. She feels so far removed from that time of her life.

"Your Princess?" He questions. She hears him jump off his perch, hears him walk closer till she feels his presence next to her. "Who is she, really?"

"I told you already, jackass!" She snaps. "There's nothing else to it- she's my princess!"

"Oh, but there is so much more to it, little sister," He says arrogantly. "The way you say it- she means something to you. Much more than you let on. I have time to listen, little sister. So much time."

She stays silent, fists tightening. She stares ahead at the sculpted face of Adora, forever serene. She can feel Shanyuan staring at her, eyeless face boring into her and her work.

"What was she to you?" He whispers inquisitively, trying to get a rise out of her. "Your best friend? Coworker? ….Your first love?"

"Shut up!" She yells, nearly snapping her sculpting tool in half. "What does it matter!?"

He huffs a laugh. “Bingo,” He comments idly, retreating back to his perch on the wall. “It seems I’ve cracked your code, little sister. I hit the right button and you get defensive; why? I mean, it lets me know when I’m right, but….”

“I’m not in love with her,” She seethes. “I’ve never been in love with her.”

“And yet, here you are,” He says, motioning to the caverns around them- all filled with murals and statues of Adora. “Sculpting her, painting her. Tell me, little sister, is this to her likeness?”

“Yes,” She spits out bitterly. “It’s not perfect, but it’s close enough.”

“Exactly!” Shanyuan exclaims. “That’s exactly it! You love the girl, enough to sit here and paint- sculpt exact replicas, enough to even know when something is just *slightly* off with it. That’s why you’re still here, isn’t it? Not revenge- no, because you love her. What is she? A god?”

“It doesn’t matter *what* Adora is!” She shouts, and it truly takes everything in her to not scream and claw the sculpture in front of her to shreds.

“So, a god,” Shanyuan comments smugly. C’yra swears she hates him, *gods,* she hates him so much right now- “That’s an entirely different kind of pain to endure, to love a god.”

She falls silent at that. She can practically hear the smile on Shanyuan's face.

"Loving a god, why, it's painful… it destroys a person," He narrates. "Loving them from afar, never being able to touch them… it kills a person. Is that what killed you?"

"She left me." She whispers, and there is *so* much hate in her voice. So much.

"She left you," Shanyuan repeats softly. "And here you are. Still loving her regardless. You're quite the devoted follower."

"Why?" She asks, voice breaking. "Why are you doing this?"

"Because revenge isn't a good enough answer for me," He answers simply, voice monotone and void of emotion. "And because you need to let go."

"Let go?" She repeats.

"Yes, you need to let go." He confirms. "What else, tell me something else about this girl. She left you, so why do you love her?"

“I don’t love her,” C’yra murmurs (thought she knows how much of a lie it is), trailing off. “I feel as though I have an obligation towards her.”

“Why?” He presses. “What kind of obligation?”

“I take promises very seriously.”

“What promise did you make to her that leaves you feeling an obligation towards her?”

“I’ll always protect her.”

He’s silent then, almost too stunned to speak.

“...Think of a new reason to live on, little sister.”

She doesn’t have to turn around to know he’s disappeared into the cat spirits.

—

One day she finds herself reminiscing on one of her previous conversations with Shanyuan- she does that a lot, trying to think of strategies to use when she leaves the caverns.

The conversation had started like all the others- Shanyuan appearing out of nowhere, sitting on his ledge and observing her, taunting her. This time, one of those ghostly cat's sat with him, in his lap as he leisurely stroked it.

"Those cats," She had said when she paused her sculpting. "Are they ghosts? Spirits?"

"What do you think?" Shanyuan replied, as relaxed as can be.

She looked down, and thought for a moment before she dared to reply, "They're coming from you- they go where you go… I just can't figure out how."

"Use your brain, little sister."

"Are they magic?" She inquired, then began to work again.

"No," He answered. "Think harder."

“Spiritual device?” She guessed, and she could tell by the click of his tongue that she had gotten it right.

“Good,” He said. “You can be much more observant than I thought. They *are* a spiritual device.”

She hummed in reply, focusing on her work at hand. “How did you forge them?”

That was the one question he never answered. This conversation, why, it had happened 2 years ago and every time she had asked, he would never answer. He always ignored her question, or simply said that there was “work to do”.

Regardless, she always tried to find a way to answer her own question. But how was it possible to create apparitions as a spiritual device? It didn’t make sense to her.

She just supposes it’s another one of those things about him that wouldn’t make sense to her.

—

She’s forgotten how it feels to be out in the real world. Or, well, “real” world- Mount Tong’lu was *not* the real world in any sense of the word. It was archaic, dystopian. Just like the Fright Kingdom.

It felt good, though, to be out of that cave and to feel the wind in her hair and let it hit her face. Being outside of the cave, though,

permitted her to really get a good look at herself- to see these changes that happened within her cavern and….

She had become an animal.

Shanyuan had laughed for, gods, what felt like an hour straight at her when she came to the realization that she had *cat* ears. She didn't think that living within a cavern would cause her to adapt so heavily to the environment, but well, here she is. A magicat.

She supposed that when she left the place, she'd be able to use her calamity power to disguise herself in whatever way she wanted, so that no one would know that her *true* form is that of a *magicat.*

For now, though, she'd have to make do.

Melog rattles at her side, as sentient as ever.

"The thing is hungry, little sister," Shanyuan pipes up from behind her. "You have to feed it."

"What do you mean?" She asks, turning back to look at him. He smiles at her and taps the tip of the sentient blade as a means to appease it.

“Spiritual weapons are like any other weapon,” He explains. “If you don’t use it, it’ll dull. Especially for your sentient saber, here- forged through blood, if you don’t feed it, it won’t serve you properly.”

“What the hell am I even supposed to feed this thing?” She asks, exasperatedly. She swats at the scimitar, annoyed with it. The saber rattles apologetically. “I haven’t eaten a meal in 6 years.”

“Oh wow, well, would you look at that!” Shanyuan exclaims sarcastically, pointing ahead. Then, he drops the emotion and goes back to being monotonous. “Up ahead, you have an excellent option for a meal for Melog.”

C’yra was confused at first before she heard it- shrieking from the top of the mountain. Up ahead, most likely trying to draw in its next meal, was the sword spirit Adonis.

She sighs dramatically and takes about three stops forward, before she determines he wasn’t worth walking up a mountain for.

“Adonis!” She calls, not bothering to raise her voice any more. The spirit heard her call, and gladly took the bait.

“The Crimson Ghost! The Mountain Demon!” Adonis roars. “She’s left her cave, she’s left her cave! Crawled out of it like the rat that she is!”

Funny, considering Adonis is much smaller than her. And she's short as it is.

"I'm a rat?" She questions, amused. "What does that make you then?"

"Why, I'm-"

"I hope it's not something embarrassing," She yawns dramatically. "You weren't planning on saying a tiger, right? Or a lion?"

The sword spirit falls silent. She raises her eyebrows in amusement, still waiting for a reply. When Adonis doesn't respond, she bursts into laughter, unbelieving. "You!? A Lion!?" She says in between laughter. "That's the funniest thing I've ever heard! You're like a monkey- all loud and annoying, just cause you want attention!"

"Who are you to talk to ME like that!?" Adonis screeches, barreling down the mountain's slope and straight at her. She doesn't even move. "I'm the GHOST KIN-"

She quite literally picks him up when he's in reaching distance.

“Ghost king?” She questions, a smirk pulling up at her lips. She snorts. “That’s just as funny as you calling yourself a lion.”

She watches as the blade spirit transforms itself into a man- pale skin, wild, white hair… yet still incredibly short. He bares his teeth at her. “Put me DOWN!” He yells, trying to be as demanding as possible.

She pretends to debate it, and that didn’t please the blade spirit in the slightest. She watches him transform his forearms into blades, so she decides to oblige with his request in lieu of his silent threat.

She throws him onto the floor as hard as she can. She watches him in amusement as he tumbles and rolls down the slightly sloped ground.

She was at a disadvantage, she’ll admit it. Throwing the blade spirit around is, well, embarrassing for Adonis, but it doesn’t deal any major damage. This fight would have to be close-quartered, and a close quarter fight against a blade spirit? Well, Adonis is always going to have the upper hand in that situation.

Regardless, C’yra has fought many people in her lifetime- and, of course, she and Melog would always be up for a challenge.

Her fight with Adonis is swift. Every part of his body is able to twist and contort to become a new type of blade. Every clash of

their blades is like lightning- loud, thundering, and the sky flashes along with it.

"Your movements are clumsy, at best," Shanyuan comments idly from his perch in a tree branch. "You said that someone told you that you're suited to sabers… did you ever ask them why?"

She growls, not appreciating the feedback in the middle of a fight with someone that she's trying to embarrass.

"No," She scowls. "What of it?"

Adonis laughs erratically, "LOOK AT THAT! The Crimson Ghost doesn't even know how to use her own weapon! STUPID! Stupid woman, YOU'RE the monkey!"

C'yra was going to respond- preferably by spitting in the man's face -but was cut off by Shanyuan.

"Quite the observation," He sighs. "But you know how to use a scimitar swimmingly, don't you?"

"Why, YES!" Adonis exclaims, attacking C'yra even harder due to the praise. "I know how to use every blade there is! I am the BEST, the most AMAZING, Adonis-"

“How about you show us then, hm?” Shanyuan cuts him off flatly, voice as monotone as ever.

The sword spirit was not one to deny his fans. C’yra watches in mild amusement as Adonis morphs one arm into a scimitar similar in shape and size to Melog.

But that changed everything- it turned a free-for-all fight into… something instructive.

“Do you see what he’s doing?” Shanyuan questions, watching C’yra and the fight intently. “He’s not stabbing- the curve of the scimitar is not designed for you to fight with the tip-”

Adonis takes this as praise, and not like he’s being used as a teaching tool for her.

“It’s designed for melee. Little sister.” Shanyuan explains. “Watch him.”

And she does. She watches him, every little change in his stance, how he attacks- she picks up on it fast.

Standard swords, like ones in the infantry in the Fright Kingdom and what she used for most of her life, are meant to thrust and to parry. It is aggressive, the motions clumsier- but, from a master

swordsman (like C'yra, or even Adora), is like a well practiced dance- an extension of the arm.

Sabers are nowhere near the same as standard swords.

As Shanyuan, and Adonis, explain- Sabers call for wilder movements, a less structured type of attack. It emphasizes footwork, moving around the enemy, striking in quick slices of the blade from the curved edge- it's focused more on dodging, rather than blocking. It is defensive in nature, truly.

Melog has that style by itself, obviously- But C'yra does not, as she primarily only ever used standard swords. But she adapts, like always- she mimics Adonis' fighting movements and structure. Soon enough, her attacks gain power, and she lands them more often.

Adonis mocks and jeers at her, oblivious to the fact that he was her teaching tool. It continues throughout the rest of the fight, until-

CRACK!

The scimitar on Adonis' right arm cracks into two, falling onto the ground, leaving him to stare at it dejectedly.

“YOU BROKE MY ARM!” He roars, looking between C’yra and the shattered saber. “MY- MY PERFECTLY FORGED SABER!”

The other arm transforms into a sword, and he begins his attacks again- laying it on thick and heavy.. But it’s a losing battle. All the ghosts watching from the hills- they know it too, and they watch in anticipation for the final strike.

She takes out his leg, his other arm- Melog attacking faster than the eye can track with bloodlust. Soon enough, the sword spirit is left on the groun, nothing more than a torso and head.

“NO FAIR!” He cries, loud and obnoxious. “THIS WAS NO FAIR! HE- HE TRICKED ME!”

Shanyuan stays quiet, anticipating C’yra to respond in his stead.

She towers over the spirit, picking it up by the neck. “You think that this- this place- Tong’lu -is fair?” She questions, slowly baring her fangs at the spirit.

“I MADE IT SO FAR!” He cries instead. “I’M THE GHOST KING!”

She tightens her grip around the spirits neck, intending for this death to be long- because really, the thing was annoying. She thinks it deserves to suffer a little bit. The ghost continues to

babble, calling her and Shanyuan all sorts of names.. Until she decides she's fed up.

She rips the head of the sword spirit clean off, and doesn't even flinch as the blood squirts on her. She simply drops the head next to the body and watches as the blood pours onto the ground.

She feels the power of the sword spirit rush into her, almost too much for her to handle. She watches Melog hack into the body happily.

Adonis had killed more ghosts in Mount Tong'lu than any other, and even more than that.

The title of "savage" was quite deceiving- because there was a broad range of ghosts that fell under this title, all varying in strengths. While all have the ability to decimate a city, some can be dealt with by priests easily, with no assistance from the gods.

Others, like Adonis, are strong enough to *kill* gods.

And, why, that's just what he had done- four, to be exact. And now, she was absorbing all of that power- the power of all the ghosts Adonis killed in Tong'lu, and the power of four slaughtered martial gods.

She was almost drunk on power. This was nothing like the strength and power that flooded into her body when she ascended, no this- this was earth shattering. She felt like she could do anything, easily.

She snaps herself back into reality and- she sees it now. A small, black leather handle on the shattered scimitar that she had broken. She reaches down, touches it- pulsing with spiritual power. She smirks and peels it off carefully.

She forges it into an eyepatch, just to spite the creature.

“How clever.” Shanyuan comments, sounding genuinely amused. “How does it feel, little sister?”

She looks around, taking everything in- because for the first time in four years, she can see out of her right eye. Granted, it will take some getting used to- being able to see out of her regular eye while also being able to see out of her eye on the hilt of Melog, but she’ll adapt.

“Heavy,” She admits. “But I don’t feel so exposed anymore.”

Shanyuan hums in response, but offers nothing more. Instead, C’yra has a question for him now: “Why are you helping me?”

He’s silent for a moment. “I don’t want there to be an incompetent Ghost King, little sister.”

It’s an excuse. She knows it is- because what does it matter to him? He’s never leaving Tong’lu. He can’t. He’s confined to the space that Mount Tong’lu takes up- destined to never set foot out of it.

So why?

It’s another one of her questions that remains unanswered by Shanyuan.

—

She retreats back into her cavern, content on mastering the art of sculpting and painting. She leaves frequently, though. She picks off the armies of ghosts that still remain.

Five years turns to six, six turns to seven.

She, in conjunction with the last remaining savage ghost on the field- the bandaged ghost -pick off the millions of ghosts that remain. Millions turn to hundreds of thousands. Hundreds of thousands turns to tens of thousands.

Only a couple hundred remain, now. And yet neither C’yra or the Forest demon have made any move to hunt each other. There have been many times over the two years that she’s entered the

kiln- waiting for her opponent. And yet they never arrive, and the kiln never closes. So, instead she lives relatively peacefully in the caverns, secluded and insane in her own special way, sculpting.

"...You know, little sister," Shanyuan says, uncertainly from behind her. "I'm not one to judge… but I feel like these sculptures of your… princess, have become more and more… scantily clad."

She freezes, her form going completely rigid. She hears Shanyuan laugh- and it's the most normal laugh she's heard from the ghost in her entire seven years in Mount Tong'lu. She sends a glare over her shoulder at him, and he just smirks.

"Your defensive nature is making me think you have a guilty conscious, little sister-"

She growls, not in the mood for teasing. Shanyuan snickers from behind her, shaking his head.

She continues to sculpt out her *not* scantily clad Adora sculpture- she's just sculpting her from memory! It's not her fault that this memory just so happens to be from one time they snuck away and went swimming in a nearby lake!

"She should have come by now," She murmurs, mostly to herself but also to Shanyuan. Shanyuan doesn't need to question her to know what she's talking about.

“You tipped the scales when you killed Adonis,” He says. “She’s most likely trying to even the scales before your battle.”

She’s silent, for a moment.

“Does it usually take this long?” She asks. “For the kiln to close, and such.”

“Oh, gods,” Shanyuan drawls. “It usually takes *much* longer. I saw that once it took fifty years for the competitors to clear the place out enough for the kiln to close.”

Fifty years. C’yra didn’t know if she could stay here for fifty years.

“There’s only the two of us left,” She mutters. “Shouldn’t that be enough?”

Only two real contenders, at least.

“The kiln closes when certain requirements have been met,” He answers easily. “But don’t mistake it for a simple facet of nature..”

C’yra wasn’t sure how she was supposed to respond, but she was sure that Shanyuan would continue.

“Back before this place was sealed…” he trails off, then shakes his head. “Do you remember those mountains? The ones that move?”

C’yra took a moment to respond, because she was quite sure what he was talking about until- yes, she remembered. They crushed a lot of the hordes of ghosts within the first year, when the ghosts were not fully aware that they moved. She nodded.

“Well, little sister, they’re earth spirits- ancient ones,” He explains. “And Mount Tong’lu is no different.”

“Mount Tong’lu is alive?” She questions, pausing her sculpting to really listen. “Sentient?”

“Not sentient, but alive.” He replies.

It’s silent, after that. A thick silence, full of tension. One that Shanyuan cuts through easily.

“The legends of this place.. On the walls of the Sun Temple… they say that there were four friends,” He’s whispering, but she can hear him completely clearly. “All in service of a higher power, of course.”

"..Higher power, like, creating ghost kings?"

"No, you imbecile," He scolds. "The gods. There were no ghost kings back then, little sister."

She stays silent, thinking. Shanyuan respects that, let's her think in her own time before continuing. She comes to realize two things:

One, that Shanyuan, at the beginning of all of this… he said that this was him home, and the way that he's speaking of these mountain spirits- so softly, quietly, with respect, something she's never heard from him before -could indicate that he very well knew those 'friends'.

Two, when scouting out the place, the only god that she could find within the kingdom that these friends could have serviced was-

"...The Crown Prince of Prime?" She murmured. "They serviced him?"

"Yes," He answered, and C'yra doesn't miss the way his face drains- even while void of blood. "....Until the very end, they serviced him."

After that, no matter how many questions C'yra asked him about it, Shanyuan did not dare answer.

—

She spends another year in her catacomb. Then she's decides enough is enough.

For months, she searches the forests of Mount Tong'lu. It shifts, which makes sense now that she knows the mountain itself is a powerful spirit. The weather conditions change with the seasons, and they are never pleasant. Winters are harsh, Summers are long and grueling. Spring and Fall are the only slight moments of reprieve- but even they are extreme.

She scours the dense forest, even resorting to sending Melog out too so that she had a better chance of finding the very last ghost.

She weeds out the lesser ghosts that remain, all in that forest. Three hundred goes to two hundred, to one hundred, to now a mere sixty. Sixty ghosts remain, and yet she can't find the last ghost.

And the kiln still won't close.

She's there, walking through the forest, searching. The fog is thick- she can barely see in front of her, but Shanyuan was right.

Only when you are blind, do you really see.

She takes sharp inhales every couple of miles, to see if she can weed out the scent of strong magic and spiritual power. *That* is her sight when the fog is as thick as it is.

And it was her lucky day.

A few miles ahead, she could smell the faint- but still strong - scent of spiritual power. She had found her target, the bandaged ghost that lurked the forests of Tong'lu.

She finds it, eventually. She's horrified to find most of the ghosts that had disappeared within this forest strung up on the trees, like some kind of trophy.

She could see the bandaged figure digging into the ground, but they stopped when they heard her approach.

"Have you come to kill me?" The ghost asks, anger low in her voice.

C'yra.. She recognized the girl's scent. She knew her. She knew this scent, knew this voice, but she just couldn't place who it was…

“You’re already dead.”

The bandages don’t cover every inch of skin- just a few places, like where her shoulder meets her arm, or where her leg meets her hip. In basic places. The girl’s skin is a sickly green color, with hair a darker shade of green and slicked back. She wears tattered, purple robes.

The ghost snorts, still facing away from her, “I didn’t know it was you.” She says, tone full of hate. “I thought you were long gone.”

Well, she supposes that confirms her thoughts- she does know her. And this ghost knows her. If only she could figure out who it was.

“Who are you?” She questions, exasperatedly. The ghost turns around and- oh, she knows. She’s changed, but she knows those features- the *eye patch* - anywhere.

“Octavia?” She whispers, in disbelief.

“I thought Shadow Weaver took care of you when she slit your throat,” She growls. “I guess I was wrong.”

“You saw that?” C’yra asks, cause she honestly couldn’t believe this whole thing.

“Of course I did.” Octavia drops her shovel. “I saw all of it. You may have killed me, but I stuck around. A mere ghost fire, haunting the kingdom. I saw your execution, that was the only thing I stuck around for.

“I didn’t think you’d come back as a ghost. But, I can’t say I’m surprised. The Fright Kingdom breeds future ghosts like it breeds soldiers.”

“Full of resentment and hate,” C’yra adds. “Full of regrets..”

The two are silent.

C’yra breaks it.

“What’s with the bandages?”

Octavia glares. “Don’t play dumb,” She growls. “You know what’s with the bandages. You’re the reason I’m like this.”

She’s confused but then- oh, yeah, she remembers. She supposes her trademark, especially after the fight with Adonis, is cutting off limbs.

In her defense… Octavia had gotten in her way, and it was a complete accident! She didn't mean to cut her arm off! Or her leg!

"...You know," Octavia says, staring her straight in the eye. "It took me a while to put myself back together. To bandage all the things you had wounded."

C'yra, of course, knows that she means that literally- Octavia quite literally put herself back together.

"Why are you here?" She questions, instead. Octavia rolls her eye.

"I needed strength." She answers. C'yra was beyond confused- she needed strength, but for what? What did she need strength for?

"Well, you have it," C'yra says, beginning to walk backwards. "Let's go to the kiln."

"No." Octavia responds, staying put. "I'm not going to the kiln."

"What!?" C'yra yells- because what? Why is she in Tong'lu if not to get to the kiln? "What do you mean no? You have to!"

“I don’t want to be a ghost king,” Octavia explains. “I just needed strength. This was the only place that had enough ghosts….. Besides, I won’t be able to bury you in the kiln.”

“No one will ever bury me.” C’yra responds quickly. “And even if I did, it would never be you. So, you can destroy yourself trying- that’s fine with me.”

She attacks first, using Melog to slice straight through her arm. She thinks the fight will be easy- quick, judging by the way the arm severs easily and lolls on the ground.

Except, nothing is ever easy for her.

She watches in horror as the arm crawls back, bandages stretching like roots on a tree, and attaches itself back to her body.

“I told you, Red Knight…” Octavia murmurs, then turns to shouting quickly- “It took a while, but I PUT MYSELF BACK TOGETHER!”

And then, it was the sound of metal clashing against metal- two swords fighting.

The fight is grueling, because of course the final fight before the kiln is. Nothing that C’yra works hard for will ever be easy.

Each clash of their swords lights up the sky- pitch black night. The sun hasn't risen, and it won't rise either. It hasn't risen in months, anticipating the release of resentment and the birth of a Ghost king. C'yra knows that the Red Sky Eclipse is on it's way, by the way the horizon was a faint red color.

No matter how many bits that C'yra slices off, it reattaches itself to Octavia's body. It doesn't matter how quick she is either- it's a losing fight.

"It's no use," Octavia yells. "You know as well as I do that no matter what you do- I won't disappear, Red Knight!"

She doesn't know what to do- and she doesn't know where Shanyuan is, either. Usually he'd be here, scolding her, yelling at her to outsmart the enemy. His absence from this fight- arguably the biggest one during her time here -is inexplicable.

She has to figure this one out on her own.

She decides to take a shot in the dark.

"Melog," She says, letting go of her scimitar. "Go cut down the ghosts."

It’s more efficient for her, and it provides her some time because the command confuses Octavia.

C’yra determines the regenerative quality of Octavia comes from the bandages. It’s not the limb that’s reattaching itself- it’s the bandages pulling at the limbs to reattach.

She begins to claw at the bandages as best as she can while dodging Octavia’s blade. It’s a slow process, and she’s doing as much damage as she was before with Melog- so, none. But it’s getting her somewhere.

Eventually, she can’t keep fighting her close quarters without a weapon. She knows Melog is done cutting down the ghosts- it’s just waiting for a command from her. She jumps as high as she can, falling back.

She locates Melog easily, and she decides she has to use the thick fog to her own advantage. The fog is thick, so thick that the stars can’t even be seen through it.

She has an advantage over Octavia. She can locate the girl by scent- something she doesn’t think Octavia is capable of doing. She could ambush her, wait in the trees and then continue tearing the bandages off of her, until it’s adequate enough that she does actual damage.

So that's what she does. Hours, she does the same thing over and over- waits, sniffs her out by scent, ambushes her, rips away pieces of the bandages and even her when she has the chance.

It takes hours. Long, grueling hours. She thinks that maybe, she could've found a better way around this- an easier way. She couldn't figure out what that easier way would've been, though.

She finishes her, though. Eventually chops one arm, one leg- then the other arm, the other leg clean off. She thinks she looks like how she left Adonis.

"You should've known," C'yra says, looking down at a glowering Octavia. "I killed you once, and you should've known I could do it again."

"It doesn't change the fact that you're still worthless," Octavia spits. "Worthless trash- hideous, look at you! Your hair, all matted- and what have you become? An animal? Shadow Weaver was right about you! Adora is better off without yo-"

C'yra swings Melog- slices a wound straight across the ghost's torso. She doesn't kill her- no, not yet. She wants to have some fun. Octavia yells in pain. Unable to do much but wiggle in pain.

Octavia continues to spit out insults, things that she thinks will get to C'yra- but she tunes her out, instead staring down at her hand. She finds it… odd, that even in death, a small piece of Adora

followed her. The piece of Adora's hair- the one Adora had ripped out of her own head and wrapped around C'yra's finger once as some type of rune, left a mark. She hadn't noticed the indent in her middle finger until just then, and when her eyes wandered off to a stray red string- a thread that was falling off of her destroyed robes -she got an idea.

The magic Adora had embedded in that piece of hair, it protected C'yra, but it was also infinitely long. Obviously, before Adora did whatever magic on it, it wasn't infinite… but whatever magic she put in it, made it like that. C'yra thinks she can replicate that, and tweak it to her own advantage.

She rips the stray piece of thread off, holds it in her hand and focuses on fusing as much magic into the thread as can- specifically longevity magic, making it infinite, and the like.

When she exits Tong'lu, she'll obviously do a rune to strengthen the magic, but this would be good enough for now.

When she deems it adequate enough, she ties the string neatly onto the indent in her finger. It looks like a short string, but when she pulls on the end….

It extends. As far as she wants, to wherever she wants. It never runs out, and it never tightens around her own finger.

“That’s enough,” She says to Octavia, beginning to wrap her torso up in the string. “No more talking, hm?”

“Who are you to tell me what to do!?” Octavia yells. “You know nothing- you *are* nothing! Nothing without Shadow Weaver- Nothing without that Princess!”

“Yeah, I guess you could say that,” She seethes, done wrapping her body in the red thread and moving now to wrap it around the surrounding tree trunks. “Nothing without Adora, hm?”

Octavia screams in frustration, wiggling against her restraints and trying to break free. “YOU’RE NOTHING WITHOUT THAT GIRL! LOOK HOW YOU ACTED WHEN SHE LEFT YOU!”

C’yra steps back, away from where Octavia lay and where she wrapped the tree’s with her never-ending thread.

“YOU WENT INSANE! YOU’RE DESTINED TO NEVER BE ANYTHING MORE THAN HER SUBORDINATE!”

C’yra smiles- not a friendly smile. The smile of someone who’s gone crazy.

She ascended, yes, and she jumped back down- and she questions whether she still holds the power to receive prayers. Just because she jumped down, it doesn’t mean she can’t hear

prayers that go towards her. But she also supposes that it doesn't matter- no one will ever pray to her. Why would they? She's a walking curse.

Still, she can't help but want to play god- play Fire Master, like Randor had intended for her to.

"Destined to be her subordinate?" C'yra questions, voice slow and leveled. "Well, that was the oath I made, wasn't it? To work for her? Protect her?"

"YOU'RE NOTHING! YOU MEAN NOTHING TO HER!" Octavia screams, all anger and passion. "WORTHLESS, USELESS, TRASH! YOU WERE ONLY GOOD AT KEEPING THAT GIRL PROTECTED FROM SHADOW WEAVER!"

"Well, Octavia, I think I'm pretty good at protecting her from other people too," C'yra sighs dramatically. "I have a promise to fulfil. You hurt Adora, a long time ago. It's time you pay, hm?"

"WHAT? WHAT SHIT ARE YOU SPEWING NOW?"

C'yra grins wickedly, tightens her grip on the thread. "I hope this time you don't come back."

Octavia continues her insults, continues her shouting- as if that'll change anything.

“I hope that you,” C’yra pulls the string, whispers: “burn.”

Everywhere the red string touches lights on fire. It sets the forest ablaze, Octavia’s screams being drowned out by the sound of tree’s burning, falling. The flames rage, shooting pillars into the sky and lighting up Mount Tong’lu- her own makeshift sun. The flames never dare reach her- never dare to touch their master. She watches it come close, though- the flames traveling up the red string and disintegrating the thread that had tied her to Octavia and the forest- but it fizzles out once it reaches its origin.

She begins her slow descent down the mountain, leisurely and peaceful. When she reaches the foot of the mountain, the ground began to rumble so violently that it nearly threw her off of her feet- and she knows.

She defeated the last opponent. She’s the lone survivor- the last test. She is the only one left, and the mountain must know it.

The kiln is closing.

She wastes no time, sprinting towards where the kiln is in the middle of the mountain. She’s almost too late- she crashes through the little opening in the kiln- the volcano -before it can fully seal itself.

She’s done it, she’s made it. Defeated all of her opponents, got stronger- and the kiln recognized that. Recognized her as the only one left, and when she leaves, she will become the Ghost King that Etheria lacks.

She sits in the kiln, now, trembling with adrenaline and the exhaustion that wracks her body that came from fighting Octavia- and, unbeknownst to her, creating a new spiritual tool for herself. But she still did it, in record time- 8 years! 8 years, it took for her to finally enter the kiln.

This was it, she just had to find a way out of it now. She feels Melog rattle against her hip happily. She’s breathing heavily, even as she strokes Melog as one would stroke a cat. They have no more battles to fight, no more evils to witness and to deal with. Just a situation in which she needs to get out of, then she can fulfill her promise. Protect Adora.

Cause she hates her, gods she hates her- but she has a promise. She promised Adora that no matter what, she’d protect her, and she would honor that promise. Adora may not have honored their promise, but she can honor this one.

She’ll be the bigger person, even if she hates her.

She laughs, out of happiness. She couldn’t help it. She was safe.

She exhales shakily and stands up, content to begin planning how she can exit the kiln- but when she looks up, she stops.

It’s rare for her to be… well, wrong. Especially about danger, or bad things. It had been trained out of her at a young age by Shadow Weaver- she always said she would be an ineffective Knight if she didn’t consider and plan for all scenarios. C’yra always knew when she would be walking into danger.

But she’s always been unlucky. She was born cursed, her fate to be forever unlucky. She should’ve known.

Her battle isn’t over- and she is far from alone.

It starts with a slow clap. “Well done little sister,” White, robotic lips curl into a bone chilling smile. “You’ve grown quite strong.”

Standing there, in the middle of the kiln, with his arms clasped behind his back.. is Shanyuan.

It daunts on her, then: He is her final battle before exiting the kiln.

Chapter End Notes

> lollllllllll i hope you guys enjoyed this one, it was a joy to write, truly. I like to think that Catra has a conflicting relationship with how she thinks of Adora- mainly cause of events that take place before her time in Mount Tong'lu. I hope that translates well in this!?

I'll have a lot to say in the end notes of the next chapter, but that's it for this one! I hope you guys enjoyed this, pleaseee remember to comment (it really does motivate me guys!) your thoughts and opinions. I'm gonna try my hardest to get the next chapter up within the week/before next week. It's gonna be an exciting one! If you're confused by anything, feel free to comment it or, you can find me at my twitter and dm me the question!!!

See you in the next one, folks!

i want to go home

Chapter Summary

For the first time in over 7 centuries, a new era begins.

Chapter Notes

chapter title comes from Chinese Satelite by phoebe bridgers!

let me preface this by saying it's long... and lore heavy.

TW: child death, mentions of child death, implied sexual content, gore, explicit language(?)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The kiln is vast- much like the caverns she had retreated into. Except, everything in the kiln was made of pure, white marble- nothing like the name of the place would have suspected.

“What is this?” She asks, looking around confused- panicked. “What is this place!?”

“What do you mean, little sister?” The ghost asks, tilting his head to the side with a smile.

“What are you doing here!?” She yells, voice trembling. Shanyuan straightens his back, stands up straight and clasps his hands in front of him.

“Why, this is my home.” He answers, tone as condescending as ever. “I thought you knew that.”

She doesn’t respond, just stands there. Staring at him, in disbelief, in shock- shocked that she’s been betrayed. Again.

“Mount Tong’lu opens more often than anyone thinks,” He says after she doesn’t say anything. “Do you know why, little sister?”

She doesn’t say anything again.

“My uncle,” He hums, voice getting softer at the mention of him. “He was a mechanic- or, well, an engineer. He never had any proper training.”

“Why?” C’yra cuts in. “Why are you telling me this? What’s the point?”

“The aqueducts,” He whispers. “My uncle built that. And everything else in this kingdom.

“Anyhow, they use forces- gravity -to carry water all throughout the kingdom to get from one place to the next..” He explains, looking up at the ceiling. “But to push it upward, it needs pressure. It requires all sorts of things- pumps, sharp angles, much more -just to push the water uphill and where it needs to be.”

“You know, this would be really fucking useful if I was a plumber,” C’yra spits. “But I’m not.”

He doesn’t entertain her today. “To relieve the pressure- there are valves. The valves release into sewers. Only half of the water gets where it’s supposed to go- the rest gets released into a sewer. That’s what this is.”

“A sewer?” She questions, voice monotone.

“A valve- to release the pressure.” Shanyuan corrects. “Little sister, tell me, what do you think happens when so much magic is sent upwards- towards the heavens?”

The realization hits her, then. “..Pressure.”

“Yes, good,” He whispers. “Resentment.. Pressure, it builds- and Tong’lu sends out its call to release it… and the underworld answers.

“Just because Tong’lu opens, however, it doesn’t mean a Ghost King will be born,” He explains. “If a ghost of the proper caliber doesn’t survive, the result will be half formed- but it won’t be a Ghost King.. no, never.”

“Does that mean that- Horde Prime, he was the only success?” She asks, confused where this is going now.

“He was the first true success,” He half-confirms. “But he was not born here… In truth, there have been two successes since his birth.”

She furrows her brows. “If that’s true, why have I never heard of them?”

He looks down now- at her, and she swears that the expression that forms on his face is one of sorrow. “Because,” He whispers, his voice haunting. “I killed them both.”

If she had a heart that beat, it’d be racing. She was horrified, what did any of this mean? Why?

“I didn’t want to close it,” He confesses. “I grew fond of you. Too fond.”

She can tell that he’s telling the truth- that he really did grow fond of her.

“When you had ascended, little sister,” His voice, honest to gods, cracks. “I was relieved… and then, you stubborn creature, you jumped right back down. That’s when I knew it- I knew that you and I… we’d end up here.”

He walks closer to her, steps slow and calculated, until he's directly in front of her. "I don't take credit for the half formed monsters this place has let out," He whispers, voice broken and full of sorrow. "But I always take credit for my successes. And you, little sister… are the third success. You- you are my third sibling."

She didn't know how she felt- this, it felt wrong. It felt like those times where Shadow Weaver would be nice to her, treat her like she treated Adora- it felt like a sin. She didn't understand.

He reaches his hand up and cups her cheek. She feels it then- his hand is cold, metallic. She always thought he looked robotic.

"I have made weapons my whole life little sister," He murmurs. "But I will not let another Ghost King exist. I will never allow it."

She looks up at him- sees his jaws open, and she knows what's coming next- he intends to devour her.

But things are never easy for C'yra, never. Never have been, and they never will be. She kicks him square in the stomach and jumps as far back as she can, clutching Melog in her hand.

He grunts, holding the spot she kicked. "Is that what you call a hit?" He groans out, looking up at her. For the first time in 8

years, she watches as he reaches up and behind his own head- and pulls off the bandages that cover his eyes. They are glowing green, like a green star. “I expect BETTER FROM YOU, LITTLE SISTER!”

He charges at her, summoning hordes of his cats. Before there were only little amounts- but with the amount he had summoned now, it rattled the ground. The cats, she realized, could condense themselves and become kittens- and they attached themselves to her, sucking out her energy and power. Her only option was to devour them, before they drained her of all power. She had to absorb them into her very core, but at the rate that they were coming- it was basically impossible.

She doesn’t want to fight him, as much as she never wanted to fight Adora. She’s grown to care about the ghost- she’s spent the past 8 years of her life with him, how could she not?

But ultimately, her affection towards the man was not enough to stop her from pursuing what she came here for. Yes, her reason for being here did change- just like he had wanted -but she was still just as passionate before, if not even more.

They fight, his eyes like the north star, drawing her in to attack. Somewhere in the haze of the fight, he touches her forehead- and then she wasn’t in the kiln anymore.

She’s little, at the edge of a forest in the middle of summer. It’s hot out, so hot that she was only in her under robes.

“Cy!” A girl, not much older than her, yells from behind her. “Wait for me, will you!?”

“I did!” C’yra yells back. “You’re just talking too long, idiot!”

The girl caught up with her, standing right next to her now. She was just an inch or two taller than her, with pale skin and blonde hair. The hair around her ears that had fallen out of her ponytail were just beginning to curl due to sweat and when C’yra met her eyes- two big, blue shining eyes met hers. They were almost gray, the more C’yra looked.

“Come on, Cy, the river is just ahead!” The girl was missing two front teeth, and she had a little bit of a lisp because of. “We can reach it before Shadow Weaver even realizes we’re gone!”

“What happens if she does realize?” She asks, fidgeting her fingers almost anxiously. Adora smiles at her, wide and bright and like the very sun that beat overhead.

“Lighten up!” Adora giggles. “She won’t notice, Cy. I promise! And, if she does… I’ll protect you!”

Adora puffs her chest out and puts her hands on her hips, trying to act all tough and warrior like. Adora had recently read a story about how Horde Prime defeated the great Eternian Emperor

Randor, and felt particularly inspired to be a warrior. C'yra smiles at her, unable to keep it in.

"Your Highness, that's my job!" C'yra exclaims. "I'm your knight!"

"Well, that's when we're older!" Adora rationalizes, walking forward and beckoning C'yra. "Right now, we can just be best friends!"

She hears a sigh in her ear. "...So young," The familiar voice calls. C'yra balls her hands into fists, clenching her jaw.

"Get out." She demands. "This is my memory. Get out."

It was such an old memory, C'yra had completely forgotten about it. She had to have been at least 8 in the memory- she remembered Adora had wanted to show her some river she found when exploring the Fright Zone's perimeter.

"That's her, isn't it?" Shanyuan asks, ignoring her. "That's the girl- your princess. Adora?"

"What does it matter to you?" C'yra spits, angry at him intruding on such a memory.

“She looks like the sculptures, the paintings,” He hums his approval. “Albeit, much younger. But I see it.”

“Leave me alone!” She roars. “Get out of my head!”

“Little sister, do you know what it means to be born under the star of solitude?” He ignores her once again. She growls.

“Yes! I’m cursed- I know I’m cursed!”

He tsks. “You know this, I know you do. I can see it.” He whispers. “Your life, it can go one of two ways- you can be the most cursed soul on the earth, or the luckiest… Little sister, what do you know of your parents?”

“Why!? Why does it matter!?” She cries, wanting nothing more than for him to stop.

“Just answer the question, little sister!” He yells– demands. She’s struck frozen- not used to him having that tone of voice.

“...My mother died, and my father left us.” She mutters. “I barely remember her, and I never knew my father.”

“He must have loved her.”

C’yra stays silent, clenching her fists harder. She can feel her nails digging into her skin- breaking it, even.

“For a child to have such a fate as yours- or, to be blessed greatly,” Shanyuan sighs. “It is always born from two parents who love each other deeply.”

If she stays where she is, she knows Adora will beckon her forwards again. And C’yra will follow her- because she always does.

“GET OUT!” She screams, frustrated and angry.

She whirls around, and there he is- Shanyuan, in the memory, behind her. She feels herself grow to her normal height, and she reaches for his neck-

The moment she touches his neck, everything goes black again.

This time, they aren’t in the kiln, they aren’t on the edge of a forest.

The world is dark.

“There you are!” A voice calls, unfamiliar to C’yra. This isn’t a memory of hers…

A boy, with blonde hair and blue eyes, turns around to face the voice. He has sharp features, similar to those of Shanyuan.

“Big brother!” The blonde exclaims, a bright smile on his face. “I was searching for you. Father wanted you.”

“Very funny, Selvyn,” The other boy says. This boy looked quite similar, almost identical to Selvyn, except his features were softer and his eyes were a sage green color. “Uncle was looking for you. Do you know where he is?”

“In his workshop, I presume?” Selvyn asks. The other boy nods his head, confirming.

“Why does father want me?” The boy questions, curious. Selvyn shrugs his shoulders.

“I’m not quite sure, brother,” He murmurs. “He said something about Princely duties.”

The boy groans loudly, throwing his head back dramatically. “I guess I’ll be off then.” The boy’s shoulders drop. “Don’t leave uncle waiting- he said it was urgent.”

Selvyn nods and watches his brother walk off dejectedly. He looks up to his brother for a plethora of reasons- but the biggest reason is because of how he handles what he'd been dealt.

He and his brother had been twins, but his brother was born first- making him the heir to the Prime throne. Selvyn, however, while still being a prince- was named his knight. Who better to protect the Crown Prince than his younger, twin brother?

He began his walk out of the palace and about the kingdom. He wasn't dressed fully in his knight garb- rather, his casual clothing. He had a habit, however, of carrying his sword around with him. He thinks he'll never go anywhere without it.

He opens the door to his uncle's shop, and begins his walk towards the back of it, where he knew his uncle would be.

CLANG! CLANG!

"Uncle?" He calls out, entering the back room only to be met with the sight of a girl, in her under robes with her sleeves fastened to her elbows, banging a hammer against a sword. The girl looks up at his voice- and she was gorgeous. He knew who the girl was- she was a skilled sorcerer, but he never thought he'd see her here.

She had skin of ivory, clear and smooth looking. Her hair contrasted her skin, a dark black color that made her skin and her dark eyes pop. Her facial features were defined yet soft, dainty yet heavy. The girl was a true beauty.

"Prince Selvyn?" The girl says, her voice soft, but it was demanding. It drew him in. He smiles at the girl and walks into the room fully.

"Selene!" He exclaims, walking over to her bench that she was working at. "Or do you prefer Light Spinner, hot shot?"

She laughs, and it's a quaint thing. Music to his ears. "I think I prefer Selene," She answers, her eyes shining brightly at him. "Is there a reason that you're here, rather than at your post beside His Highness, Helios?"

"Yes, actually," He looks around the back room again. "I'm looking for my uncle. My dear brother said he was looking for me?"

"Oh, yes, he was!" She confirms, putting down the hammer and leaning on the workbench. "It has something to do with that gift you plan on giving his highness for his birthday. He's stepped out of the store for a bit, though."

"Oh?" Selvyn says, his voice low. "I guess I'm stuck with you then, hm?"

Their faces are inches apart, across from each other at the workbench. Selene's smile was as bright as the sun, as her eyes darted from his eyes to his lips.

"Yeah," She murmurs. "I guess you are."

Their lips connect briefly at first, but then more hungrily the second time around. She ends up reaching a hand up to his cheek, leaving a grease mark on his clean face.

'Oh my god' C'yra thinks to herself, in disbelief as she watches the memory.

"Alright! That's enough, love birds,"

The two jump away from each other at the sound of Selvyn's uncle's voice. Selvyn cranes his neck to see his uncle, who's wiping his dirty hands on his white robes and slinging a towel over his shoulders.

"I understand you two have been together for a while now," He chuckles, walking over to the bench and standing next to his nephew. "But there will be no… fornication within my store! You hear me?"

“Uncle!” Selvyn exclaims, horribly embarrassed. Selene laughs behind her hand, shaking her head.

“Yes sir, Mr. Tong’lu,” She says. “Your terms are acceptable.”

Mr. Tong’lu laughs heartily, slapping a hand on Selvyn’s back. “Come on now, son,” He says once he’s calmed down. “Let’s go to my office and leave Ms. Weaver to her work, alright?”

“Yes, uncle,” Selvyn concedes, sending a shy smile to his girlfriend. “I’ll see you later?”

“Yeah, of course.” Selene replies, shooting her own smile back, then continued work on forging a blade.

Mr. Tong’lu led him to his back office- the very back of the store.

His uncle was the only one who knew about him and Selene. They’d been dating for around a year now, and kept it tightly under wraps. No one could know about them.

“And, here we are,” Mr. Tong’lu says, more to himself than to Selvyn. He sits down at his desk and beckons Selvyn to sit down across from him as well. “Sit down, your highness.”

Selvyn does as told and gladly takes the seat opposite from his uncle. They're silent, just staring at each other.

"You wanted to see me about brother's present?" Selvyn asks, curious to what his uncle would need to speak to him about.

"Yes, and something else but," Mr. Tong'lu sighs. "The blade is almost done. Do you intend to give it to him on your birthday?"

"Yeah," He confirms, nodding his head. "I do. Why?"

"No reason other than delivery purposes."

It's silent again, but the silence was… tense.

C'yra felt uncomfortable, just watching it.

"What's the other reason you needed me here, uncle?" Selvyn questions, fidgeting nervously in his seat. He watches his uncle visibly deflate as he sighs again.

"When are you going to break it off?" He asks, almost pleading. "Your brother.. The Crown Prince, he turns 18 in what, 2 weeks? He picks a wife on his birthday out of his harem- and you know that Selene is the obvious pick."

He stays silent. He knows it’s the truth, and this was the risk of dating someone within his brother’s royal harem- the risk of him picking her.

“You know he’ll pick her, your highness,” Mr. Tong’lu says. “You should see how he acts around her, it’s- it’s a given.”

“You never know, uncle,” Selvyn pleads. “You never know! He- he might choose another girl.”

‘He won’t!’ C’yra thinks, trying to whisper it through time to him. ‘He won’t…’

Mr. Tong’lu pushes out of his chair and stands up, looking down at his nephew. “You know what you have to do, your highness.” He says, resolute in his decision. “Don’t break that girl’s heart by dragging her along like this. Your duty is to your brother first and foremost, and no one else- let alone a girl. Do you hear me?”

“Yes, Uncle,” Selvyn murmurs. “I hear you, loud and clear.”

C’yra watches Mr. Tong’lu leave the room, leaving Selvyn to sit there in his thoughts.

She watches time pass, presumably to the day of the two boys' birthday. Their 18th birthday.

They're all sat at a long table, elevated in a dining hall full of people. In the middle is sat a man, older and wearing a crown, next to a woman around his age, also in a crown. She thinks that's the King and Queen of the Prime Kingdom- sat next to them, on each side, are two boys. The side next to the king sits Selvyn and his brother, Helios- the Crown Prince.

"We're gathered here, today, to formally declare who will be the Queen Consort of my son, Prince Helios, upon his ascension to the throne!" The king announces to everyone in the hall joyously, and he smiles as the dining hall erupts into cheers.

Selvyn was always forgotten on their birthday, as the younger twin. It was alright, he supposed. He was destined to live in his brother's shadow. He always had his two younger brothers, Anastas and Galen, who sat on the side of their mother.

Although he smiled, there was a gnawing feeling of dread in his stomach. He had a feeling he knew who his beloved brother would pick.

"Will the young women please step forward?" The king calls, watching intently as the 7 women hand picked for the boy step forward.

C’yra knows. She knows who Helios will pick.

Helios stands up, hands clasped in front of him, smile wide and beaming.

“It took me quite a while to decide, as you’re all lovely women,” He explains, eyes darting and glancing towards each girl, before landing on one. “But ultimately, I think… I have the most chemistry with Ms. Selene Weaver.”

The dining hall cheers, and the other girls clap for Selene, but she can see the sorrow in her face. She can see the destroyed, haunted look that Selvyn had on his face, too.

He claps for his brother either way.

The memories progress, showing the months as they fly by- Selvyn joining his brother on outings to other kingdoms, him in training -but the haunted look he had in that dining hall remained. None of his smiles reached to his eyes, they were half-assed and fake at best.

No one noticed.

The only moments of true peace and happiness Selvyn had was when he sat in the kingdom’s alley’s, stroking the backs and heads of the alley cats that had been left and forgotten about.

He felt a kinship to them, C'yra learned.

It stops on a memory of Selvyn and Selene.

"This garden is beautiful, you know." Selvyn hears from behind him- and when he turns his neck, he sees her. His only love, bathed in the moonlight she was named after. "When I found it, I knew it'd be my favorite part of the palace."

He looks down at his lap, where he was petting the stray cat. "Yeah," He agrees, voice quiet and downturned. "It's peaceful. It's best at night- everyone is asleep, so it's not so.. busy."

"Yeah, I can see," She laughs quietly, walking over to him. "Is anyone sitting here?"

He looks up at her, and gods, she looks so beautiful. So, so beautiful. He could never resist her- that's the whole reason he got into this mess. He accepted her advances.

"No, no one," He muttered. "The seat is all yours, Selene."

She murmurs a quick, "thank you," and sits down beside him, softly stroking the flower petals of a flower she had picked up. She didn't look at him, didn't dare to.

“How are you and… his highness?” He forces himself to ask- because it’s the polite thing to do. Polite to ask the love of his life how she and his brother are doing, because only his brother’s happiness matters.

“We’re… okay,” She offers gently. “Helios keeps suggesting to His Majesty to set you up with another girl from the harem.. but nothing ever comes of it.”

“Good, I'm glad,” He says, letting the bitterness seep through. “I don’t want his help regarding my love life.”

“I get it,” Selene sighs. “I understand. I’ll tell him to back off, okay?”

He nods, but says nothing else. He just watches the cat purring peacefully in his lap.

“Is it bad that I miss you?” Selene whispers out of nowhere, her voice breaking. He stops petting the cat, frozen in his very spot at the confession.

“You shouldn’t,” He whispers back, distraught but selfishly happy that she admitted it. “...but I- I miss you too, Sel. Impossibly so.”

He looks at her, then- he wants her to know just how much he misses her. He wants her to know that it's genuine.

"I wish he chose someone else," Selene continues, finding herself unable to stop. "I wish it everyday. I won't be able to be with him properly… not anymore, not since I know how it feels to be with you, your highness."

"...I know," He shuts his eyes tight, unable to look at her and her beautiful dark eyes straight on. She was like the sun- she was his sun, and he was flying too close to her. "I know you do, Sel. I do too."

"Your Highness," She practically begs, reaching her hand up to cup his cheek. "Please.. Indulge this poor servant this once, won't you?"

"We shouldn't.." He murmurs, opening his eyes and meeting her pleading ones. "We can't. You're- You're promised to my brother. I should mean nothing to you."

"You'll never mean nothing to me," She pushes. "You- You will always mean the most to me. Please, please Selvyn."

She was begging. He's never seen her beg before- not like this. Not with such need.

He glances between her lips and her eyes, before barely nodding his head. “Okay,” He relents. “Okay.”

She wastes no time in capturing their lips, pouring as much love into it as she can. It was passionate- it was rough, needy. It was months of longing- of forlorn glances towards one another across the dining table, of barely there touches and grazes of hands in the hallway.

The cat jumps out of his lap, and Selene wastes no time in taking the cat’s place, continuing to kiss him just as ferociously.

When her hands begin to roam, only then does he pull away, breathless.

“We shouldn’t do this here,” He whispers, chest heaving. “Not when anyone can walk in.”

“So what?” She responds, trailing wet, open mouthed kisses from his jawline to his neck. “Who cares who sees, your highness…”

“What’s gotten into you?” He gasps when she sucks on a particularly sensitive spot of his neck. He cranes his neck to the side to give her more access, his hands finding her hips. “This would be quite the position for us to be found in.. The Crown Prince’s Queen consort, on top of his twin brother. We’ll be shunned…”

She stops then, and she pulls away. She stares into his deeply, a foreign look on her face. “Okay, you have a point, your highness…” She says, her voice breathless. “Take me to your bed chamber, then.”

It was the birth of an illicit affair, between the Crown Prince’s soon-to-be wife, and his brother. His knight.

She watches months turn to years, years of this affair between Selvyn and Selene. Stolen glances, clandestine meetings under moonlight in the garden- she can see it tearing Selvyn apart.

She knows. She can feel it, can feel the guilt he has for betraying his beloved brother in such a way, and she can feel the love he has for the girl. It’s overbearing- it’s too much, and he’s too close-

It’s the eve of their wedding.

“We can’t keep doing this, Selene,” He says, staring down at her. She was dressed in red robes- customary for weddings in the Prime kingdom. She looks gorgeous. “It isn’t fair to any of us.”

“Yes we can,” She smiles, grabbing his hands and letting their conjoined hands hang between them. “It doesn’t hurt anyone. No one but us knows..”

“He loves you, Selene.” He presses. “You, Selene. He loves you, and only you.”

“I know he does, Selvyn,” She sighs. “But I love you! Can’t you see that- that I love you!”

“It’ll pass.”

She’s struck silent at his words, eyes widening.

“You’re marrying him tomorrow,” He continues, wasting no time. He slips his hands out of hers, and looks down at his feet- he can’t look at her. “You’ll be the new Princess. You’ll be crowned Queen one day. I’m nothing to you, Selene. A friend, perhaps, but nothing more.”

“You can never mean nothing to me!” She pleads, voice shaky. “You can never just be my friend! It’s impossible, Selvyn- please! Let’s run away together! I- I love you!”

“You need to love Helios.” He turns his head away from her. “Stop loving me.”

“I can’t, why don’t you understand that!?” She cries, clutching onto his robes. “I can’t stop loving you! I know- I know you love me, Selvyn!”

“I don’t love you,” He spits, and gods does it hurt him. Cause he does love her- loves her so deeply. He won’t love anyone after her, he knows- but he can’t keep doing this with her. “I have never loved you. I never will. Why, why do you refuse to be with someone who does love you? Why do you insist on loving me- someone you will never have?”

He figures the only way she will listen to him is if he is harsh- if he lies to her. Tells her lies, tells her that he never loved her and never will, to get her to move on in order to love his brother. It hurts him, it hurts him so much.

‘Fool!’ C’yra cries, watching the scene play out in front of her. She doesn’t dare say it out loud- he doesn’t know she’s there, watching his memories. ‘You’re a fool!’

Tears cloud Selene’s vision, her expression that of a broken little girl. “You’re a liar, you know that?” She seethes, sticking her finger into his chest. “You’re a- you’re a liar! These past 3 years, what? What have they been to you? Fun? An Adventure? You never loved me!?”

“Just leave, Selene,” He pleads. “Go back to your room. Get ready for your wedding.”

“Go FUCK yourself, Selvyn!” She yells, pushing him back. “You’re a fucking LIAR! You- Gods, I hope you rot!”

She hits him, punching and slapping his chest, doing anything she can to hurt him like he hurt her.

She fails to realize that he already is hurt.

"I never- I never want to see you again!" She yells, pushing him one last time before stopping, watching his face for any kind of regret. When she sees none, she turns sharply on her heel and begins to walk out of the garden.

She thinks he can't hear her, when she screams out in frustration and anger. But he hears it, loud and clear.

The next day is the wedding, and she looks divine standing on the stairs of the pavilion in her wedding robes- the color of maple red. You can't even tell that just a night prior, she was crying her eyes out, yelling, hitting her groom's brother.

And then it's just him and the alley cats, again.

The months bleed into years again, and she watches from afar as Selene genuinely falls in love with the Crown Prince.

It's no surprise to her when their first child is born, on a sunny spring day. Selvyn visits his nephew frequently, builds a bond with

him.

It falls through, one day.

She doesn’t see it- the memories don’t permit her to.

But she can hear it. Hear the anguished cries of a mother on the edge, begging, pleading for someone to help her- to help her little boy, just born a month or two ago. It breaks something in the memories.

“We need to go to war!” Helios demands, slamming his hand down onto the table. He was a grieving father- no one held this against him. “Those- those bastards, they stole my son! Hexed our family, stole my son’s soul right out of his body! This is an act of war!”

Selvyn stands up, nodding towards his hysterical brother. “I agree with his highness,” He announces. “What they did was despicable, and most certainly an act of war. We must retaliate- immediately.”

The king, hair graying prematurely, sighs with his head in his hands. “What do you say, Galen? Anastas?” The king questions, dragging his hands down his face.

The two brothers look at each other, then at their elder brothers. “We agree,” Galen speaks up on behalf of him and his younger

brother. “They took our nephew away from us. This is an act of war.”

The king clasps his hands together and nods his head, accepting. “Then that’s that.” He announces. “Ready the troops, we’re going to war with Mystacor and its sister nation, Brightmoon.”

Tragedies continue to befall the Prime Kingdom.

The king and queen pass on the eve of the troops being sent out, due to a passing plague. It wasn’t supposed to be serious.

Helios and Selene are coronated the next day to keep the Kingdom in as much order as they can keep it in.

And there is war.

Selvyn follows his brother- the king -into battle. He always will. He will never not protect his brother- because that was what he was born to do. He made an oath, when becoming his knight, to always protect his brother.

So, that’s exactly what he will do.

He watches his brother go mad, on that field. He goes mad with grief, striking down soldier after soldier, searching for the one who did such a thing to his family.

He thinks he finds the man who does it. It's a suspicion, it's not fact. Yet Selvyn backs him up- stands with Helios when he tells Selene he thinks he's found the guy.

"I know who did it," he whispered. "I know who took our child."

Selvyn watched as the light returned to Selene's eyes- like she was regaining her soul. "Who?" She asked, hopeful. "Who- who!?"

Helios has an explanation- about how Mystacor was scrambling for power, wanted their territory, so they placed the curse upon their family in order to do it, they stole the soul of the heir to ensure their success.

Selvyn knows none of this is fact. He just wants an excuse to tear them down, out of his grief. He wants to avenge his son, and Selvyn understands- he wants to avenge his nephew, too. But this wasn't the right way, making things up…

He'd stand by his brother no matter what.

"I know how we can make them pay," He said, smiling up at his wife. "I know a way."

“Name it.” She demands.

“A blade,” He murmurs. “I need you to forge me a blade. The finest blade you can forge, my love.”

She nods, slowly at first but then fiercely when it truly sinks in. “I can do that,” She whispers, voice cracking. “Of course I can do that- When do you need it by?”

“As soon as possible,” He smiles brightly at her, holding her face in his hands. “As soon as possible.”

She stands abruptly, getting ready to leave when-

“I don’t want you to go alone, my love,” Helios speaks up from his position on his knees. “Please, take my brother with you.”

They lock eyes.

“That isn’t a good idea, brother,” Selvyn says uneasily, darting his eyes from Selene to his brother. “I need to be by your side, to protect you, don’t I?”

“Nonsense, brother,” Helios waves him off. “I’m more than capable of protecting myself for a while. Please, watch over my beloved wife for me while I attend to my duties… she’s in good hands with you.”

Selvyn sighs and looks at Selene. She looks conflicted, but nods either way. “Okay, that’s fine.” She accepts, her tone clipped. “Get up, we’re going now.”

“Yes, your majesty,” He says, standing up and walking towards her. She’s already out the door, but he still turns to his brother and bows lowly in respect. “Stay safe, brother. Don’t do anything drastic without me.”

“You know I never will.” Helios jokes, bowing towards Selvyn as best as he could.

The walk to the blacksmith shop is silent, and mainly professional for the most part.

He stands guard, making sure the Queen stays safe- but he watches her form, as well. She was never the best blacksmith- he was better than her by miles, but the way she put her all into it.. He could see the rage in her, see the grief and the hope she held.

She was still forging the sword wrong.

“You’re doing it wrong,” He says softly, walking towards her. “Let me help.”

“Don’t touch me!” She spits out, stilling slamming the hammer onto the blade to get it into place. She stops when he puts his gloved hand over hers on the hammer.

“Let me help you, your majesty,” He pleads. “You can hit the blade as much as you want, but if you aren’t doing it right, it will never be the blade that his highness needs. Let me help.”

She says nothing else, lets Selvyn get behind her and slowly teaches her the correct movements and the proper form. Her body is rigid against his, but he finds the more he talks her through it, the more she relaxes.

Eventually she got it, and his help was no longer needed. So he watched, watched her form the sharpest, most durable blade the world has ever seen. 100 layers of the finest metals she could find.

When she hands the sword over to her husband, he designates it as the “Sword of Protection”. The name sticks- and she knows. C’yra knows. She remembers the stories Shadow Weaver would tell the soldiers- that the Sword of Protection, before it was in the hands of the Eternian Emperor, was forged for Horde Prime.

She knows, then. She knows who Helios will become- Hordak, Horde Prime.

Selvyn see's how deadly the sword is first hand, fighting side by side with his brother. The blade becomes a mythical thing- leaving multiple cuts in each target that he strikes, one for each layer of hatred that Selene hammered into the blade.

The war doesn't go for much longer after that- the final battle is so monstrous that it brings Brightmoon and Mystacor to their knees, but it is not without losses on both sides.

Their brother, Galen, dies in the final fight.

Helios ascends to heaven during that very fight, as well.

Selvyn lost two brothers that day.

He collects the soul of his brother Galen, for safekeeping. He didn't want to risk losing his brother permanently.

The funeral for his brother is the same day as the coronation of Selene- from Queen consort to Queen. The Prime Kingdom's first, and last, Queen.

At the funeral, he finds his uncle.

"Uncle," Selvyn says to get his uncle's attention. "Can I speak to you about something?"

"Of course," Mr. Tong'lu, now in his mid 60s. "What is it?"

"..You're smart," He darts his eyes around the room, making sure no one was eavesdropping. "I saved Galen's soul from the battlefield. I was wondering if you could do anything with it? To preserve his soul, or something?"

He watches a slow, blood-curdling smile form on his uncle's face. "You're in luck, your highness," He whispers. "Follow me, I have just the thing for you."

So, he follows his uncle to a secret room in the palace- one that Selvyn didn't even know existed. It was pitch black in the room until Mr. Tong'lu lit a candle- and he saw it.

Tens, hundreds of robotic looking people. They all looked identical to one another- identical to Helios, but stripped of all color and originality.

"His Majesty designed them, a while ago," Mr. Tong'lu informs him. "Said he wanted them plain, to look all the same with the colors of the kingdom- White and black."

Selvyn walks over to one, amazed and slightly horrified. He runs his hand over the robes of the robot- he sees it now, the emblem of the Kingdom in the middle of the robe. He supposes that they're on all the clones' robes.

"Why?" He asks, in complete disbelief. "I mean, like… what prompted this?"

"The death of his son," Mr. Tong'lu explains. "He wanted a way to preserve a soul should someone die. I figured out a way- and this was it."

Mr. Tong'lu walks over and turns the clone's head. "All you have to do is place the soul that you recovered into a jar- and then the jar connects to a tube that connects to this port here on the back of the clone's neck," He points at the chip. "The tube funnels the soul into the clone and… there you go, the person has now been permanently preserved in the body of a robot."

"...And the person acts the same?" Selvyn questions, looking between his uncle and the clone. "As they did in their mortal life?"

"It's like how a ghost works, sort of," Mr. Tong'lu chuckles. "Ghosts are the same person that they were when they're alive, just dead. It's the same thing, except instead of being a ghost… you're a robot!"

"..And you can do that, for Galen?" Selvyn asks softly. Mr. Tong'lu nods his head in confirmation, smiling brightly.

"Of course I can. Leave it all to me, your highness."

And it works. Galen is born again into a robot. It takes a while to adjust, but eventually the palace gets used to it.

The Kingdom prospers under Selene, but the citizens are less than enthusiastic about her. They call her all sorts of names.

Selvyn had found her alone in the garden, once. It was past midnight, and she was just sitting there. Staring, petting one of the stray cats that had wandered into the garden.

When the cat was alerted of Selvyn's presence, it ran over to him- far more acquainted with him and his presence than that of Selene's.

"I always wanted my children to play in this garden," She says softly. He can hear her perfectly clear. "It's my favorite place in the palace… It's the most beautiful place in the world."

"You don't know that," Selvyn comments, sitting down beside her on the bench. "You should've seen some of the places I've been…

far more beautiful than this, in my opinion."

"It doesn't matter to me," She responds. "This will always be it for me. You can't deny its beauty, can you?"

He wasn't looking at the garden. He was staring at her, thinking of her, when he says, "...Yeah, I can't. It is truly beautiful."

She smiles softly, smile as radiant as ever. She was more beautiful now then she was then- and he supposes that's what aging does to people.

He looks away and down at the cat in his lap. He feels a sense of deja vu, sitting here with her.

"I wanted the same thing, you know," He whispers. She looks at him questioningly, "To bring my children here?"

"Ours," He corrects mindlessly, not evening realizing what he had said until it was too late.

"Selvyn…" She murmurs, voice breaking.

"You haunt me," He confesses, already too deep in to stop. "The look on your face the night before your wedding. I lied to you,

then. I had to."

She doesn't say anything- can't say anything.

He continues. "I couldn't keep being with you behind my brother's back, it hurt far too much… So I had to lie to you, and I regret it everyday.. Gods, Selene, I regret all of it everyday. I will never love anyone but you. You're it for me- the only one."

"What are you.." She trails off, a shocked look in her eye- but hopeful. "What are you saying?"

"I wanted to marry you," He confesses. "To have children with you. I wanted that with you. But brother- brother always comes first. I will always live in his shadow, and I… I'd rather you be happy with my brother, than with anyone else."

It's an act of impulse when Selene leans in and kisses him. She clings to him, like he's the oxygen she needs to breath-

Selvyn should be ashamed for betraying his brother like this again- but he's learning that his happiness matters too. He wasn't built to just be his knight, wasn't destined to be just a knight. He has his own destiny, his own life to live.

In the week's that follow, Selene allows her husband to kiss her again when he visits heaven. Allows things to go further between

them, again.

Selvyn can’t remember ever hearing stories about a sitting god fathering a child, but he figures his brother will figure it out when he watches Helios and Selene look down at their second child.

Selvyn doesn’t feel all consumed by his grief anymore either. He relishes in the moments when Selene smiles at him over her husband's shoulder- and she looks happy, full of life again. He doesn’t feel haunted by her any more.

They’re haunted by the truth, sure- but he’s not haunted by her.

Their son, his nephew- is born under the star of solitude.

“Do you think it’s bad luck?” Helios asks Selvyn one day, on a visit. “You know, being born under the Star of Solitude?”

“No,” Selvyn murmurs, looking down at the child. His nephew had blue eyes. “It doesn’t mean that… it does, however, mean that his parents love each other deeply.”

Helios smiles, looking down at his son in awe. “I was confused, you know,” He admits softly. “When he opened his eyes, and his eyes were blue. I figured his eyes would be green like mine… Selene just said that her eyes used to be like that, too. She think’s they’ll turn dark eventually.”

Selvyn smiles, but he knows the truth. The boy's eyes won't turn dark. His eyes will stay blue.

They name their son Randor, and the kingdom celebrates the birth of the second child- the new heir.

The kingdom finally knows peace. Their god- "The Sun God", as they call him -is kind and he is generous, their harvests always bountiful and long. Their Queen is beautiful and she, too, is kind. She rules gently but is harsh when she needs- and they have a beloved crown prince.

Selene watches her son grow into a playful smart- and Selvyn has a student now. He teaches his nephew the art of the sword in the garden, while Selene sits on the bench, watching her brother-in-law and son while petting the garden cat.

The memories that pass C'yra- they're the happiest ones she sees of Shanyuan. The happiest she probably will see of him, because she knows best that happiness always ends eventually.

She finds out that Eternia was a kingdom long before it was ever considered the official term for heaven.

War returns to the Kingdom of Prime, when the Eternian Kingdom rises and seeks to avenge the terrible defeat of Brightmoon.

Selvyn goes to battle, this time without his brother. No matter how many times he prays to his brother- he doesn't respond.

And when he does respond, his brother simply tells him that he can't help. Before, he was able to aid in the war efforts, but now that he is a god, he can't interfere.

The great Kingdom of Prime is losing the war.

Selene tries to engage in peace talks, but each time they try to settle on a peace treaty, the Eternian kingdom always has one condition:

They get Prince Randor.

The Eternian Queen, due to previous health issues, is unable to have a child- and the kingdom needs an heir.

Selene strictly turns it down each time- under no circumstance will she give her child, her son, who is barely 8 years old, away to another kingdom in order to make peace.

Selvyn agrees with her- he doesn't want to lose his nephew.

Yet, in the very last meeting before the end of the war, Selene agrees to hand over her son. He can tell it guts her to do so, but she does it nonetheless.

She says it's what they must do in order to save the kingdom.

She becomes a shell of a woman, again. He sees his brother try to comfort her, try to assure her that they can always have another child- but Selvyn sees the look of guilt on her face.

Each time, she shrinks away from her husband and Selvyn knows where she goes. She goes to the garden, or more often than not, to Randor's room.

Selvyn had painted cats all over the wall, ranging from all sorts of colors- but his favorite were always he white ones.

He stands in the hallway, now, listening to her muffled cries.

"...Do you think that he knew?" C'yra speaks up from behind him. He hangs his head, staring at his feet.

"No," He responds. "If he knew, he would've killed Randor."

She doesn’t know what else to say to him, except for- “Was he the one who took your name? Selvyn?”

He doesn’t respond to her, and that’s all the answer that she needs. “When did he take your name?”

“Get out,” Shanyuan growls. When C’yra says nothing, he turns on his heels and starts hurling things at her- anything he can find in that hallway. “GET OUT!”

He doesn’t want her watching his memories anymore.

She stands there, letting him throw whatever he wanted at her, all while screaming at her to get out.

His hands grip her face- and pitch black, again.

Not the kiln.

Not the edge of a forest.

Not the Palace of the Prime Kingdom.

There’s the sound of splashing- of giggling.

It’s two girls, around 13 years old, in a river together.

She knows this memory. It hurts.

“You’re such an ass!” C’yra shrieks, trying to get out of the river but failing every time Adora splashes more water at her. “Let me out!”

“Come on!” Adora laughs, swimming around leisurely and splashing C’yra. “It’s not that bad!”

“Did Shadow Weaver put you up to this!?” C’yra yells, finally giving up and accepting her fate. Adora snickers and shakes her head, “No! I just wanted to have fun with you- is that such a crime?”

“Yeah, it is when Shadow Weaver can pop out at any second!”

Adora rolls her eyes and mutters something about C’yra being ‘no fun’, and continues to swim around.

Shanyuan distantly thought Adora looked familiar.

C’yra stuck to the river bank- never going farther than where she could touch.

“Come in deeper, Cy!” Adora calls, in the deepest part of the river. “It’s not so bad, I promise.”

“I don’t know…” C’yra mumbles, but relents nonetheless. She gently pushes herself off of the river bank and walks towards Adora.

Adora comes in and saves the day, of course. She grabs C’yra’s arms and essentially acts as her floatie.

“See?” Adora smiles brightly. “Not so bad!”

“Yeah, I guess…” C’yra mumbles. “Let go of me, idiot.”

Adora worries her eyebrows together. “I don’t know if that’s a good idea..”

“Just do it!”

Adora lets go hesitantly- and it was a very bad idea, because C'yra immediately begins sinking into the river. C'yra can't float, she doesn't even know how to swim- she was drowning, basically.

And Adora was an idiot. A big, fat idiot. She did the only thing she could think of- which was, of course, inhaling as much air as she could, dipping underwater, and connecting their lips in order to pass air to C'yra.

She pulls her up, too- their lips still connected all the while, even after all the air has been passed to C'yra and she realizes- Adora is kissing her.

She's kissing Adora- Adora is kissing her. Right there. In the river behind the palace.

It's a blissful moment, of C'yra clinging to Adora, while Adora's arms were thrown leisurely around her shoulders.

It's cut short, because nothing good ever happens to C'yra.

The issue with kissing your best friend- and your responsibility -so close to your place of work, is that your boss can catch you.

And they got caught.

C’yra felt frozen in place, and no matter how she struggled, she couldn’t move.

She feels herself being lifted out of the water and toward the solid ground- she could see the scared look on Adora’s face.

Shadow Weaver was there, manipulating C’yra’s body with her magic. She makes a slight movement with her hand- and C’yra’s body contorts. It felt like she was being struck by tiny lightning bolts all over her body.

It hurt. Gods, it hurt. It hurt, it hurt, it hurt, it hurt-

Shadow Weaver tsks- and Shanyuan realizes. He knows who that is. He should’ve known by just looking, but…

“What are you doing C’yra!” Shadow Weaver yells- and gods, Shanyuan knows. He knows, he knows, he knows.

“Are you corrupting her!?” Shadow Weaver accuses. “Adora, get out!”

Adora complies immediately.

Shanyuan knows who Shadow Weaver is- and by association, he sees it. He realizes who Adora is, or rather, who Adora looks like.

Randor.

Shanyuan doesn't passively watch C'yra's memories anymore. He charges through them, soaking up every glimpse he can get of both Shadow Weaver and of Adora.

He sees the bitter ghost that Shadow Weaver had become, how hateful she was- but he saw how she treated Adora. She treated her questionably, but it was nothing compared to how he saw her treat the others. She placed Adora on a pedestal, she wanted her to succeed.

He knows why.

He watches the tragedy unfold- watches Shadow Weaver wipe Adora's memory of the kiss, leaving C'yra to be the only one who remembers it. He watches C'yra do everything she can to please Shadow Weaver, to make her proud- but he knows that nothing she could do would ever get her to be proud. Not unless it was Adora who did it.

He watches C'yra slowly fall in love with her, whispering 'tell her, you stubborn girl,' every time the two were alone together.

He watches C’yra fall down a similar path to him- working for someone she loves endlessly and would do anything to protect, even if it meant she wasn’t happy. And she wasn’t- not with how Shadow Weaver and everyone else treated her.

He watches their fight, when Adora says she’s leaving to search for ‘godhood’ and C’yra argues to bring her with. Watches Adora tell her no, that she has to go on her own. ‘Tell her!’ He tries to whisper through time to C’yra. “Tell her how you feel, little sister!”

He watches C’yra slowly realize that Adora isn’t coming back like she said she was. Watches as C’yra’s love for the girl turns to hate in her descent into madness- he watches the girl throw herself into her work, doing all that she can to capture Brightmoon.

He sees what led to her death- how on the night of the Red Sky Eclipse, C’yra snapped. He watches the half-baked, completely botched assassination attempt on Shadow Weaver- he sees the execution itself.

It was cruel. It was torture.

It was public, and it took hours. It took her hours before Shadow Weaver was done with her for good, happy to get rid of her for good.

He watched the fragmented remains of the love of his life abuse these children, for no good reason other than out of bitterness for what she could never have. He knows what Shadow Weaver saw in C'yra- she saw him, in her, and that's why she hated her so much.

The memories progress past her death, too. He watches Shadow Weaver take C'yra's name, just like how his brother stole his.

He watches a ghost fire meet Adora- now much older, but she has a haunted look to her.

"What are you doing here?" Adora asks the ghost fire, curiously. "Do you need help moving on?"

"No," The ghost fire responds. "I still have duties."

"Duties?" Adora questions, a little amused. "What kind of duties do you have?"

"I need to protect someone," The ghost fire says. "I have to protect my beloved."

Adora smiles sadly at the ghost fire. "I'm sure your beloved would like for you to rest peacefully. What would they think if they found out you're unable to move on because of them?"

“I’ll never let them know.” The ghost fire answers, stubborn. “I can protect them from afar.”

“Don’t you want to move on?” Adora murmurs, confused but impressed by the ghost fire’s determination. “To rest in peace?”

“I pray to never rest in peace.”

He watches the ghost fire follow Adora around helplessly- and Shanyuan thinks that whatever happened to C’yra left her memory half wiped. Why would she follow Adora around like this after dying with such hatred for her?

Nonetheless, he watches Adora go on a death mission- watches as the ghost fire follows Adora into the battle, as she gets captured by Shadow Weaver and discovers C’yra’s death.

And then he watches Adora’s ascension, and how she doesn’t come back down.

Months bleed into years of Ghost Fire C’yra wandering the world aimlessly, until she finds Adora again. He watches her try to warn Adora to not enter the temple, to not trust Shadow Weaver.

He watches the ghost fire look on helplessly as its first love is tortured in front of her, in the same manner she was before her death.

Shanyuan watches the birth of a savage ranked ghost in that very temple.

He watches that savage ghost watch over Adora in the temple, slowly nursing her body back to health- until Adora wakes up. He watches Adora remember everything that happened to her- watches Adora look at all the scars littered over her body because of her and vows to get revenge.

The savage ghost agrees.

“What’s your name?” Adora asks harshly- it’s the harshest that Shanyuan has seen of Adora throughout C’yra’s memories.

“I have no name,” the savage ghost says, bowed before Adora. “I do not have a name any more, your highness.”

“..To be without a name is to be Wu Ming,” Adora rattles off, then attempts to lift C’yra off her knees. “We have work to do.”

He watches Wu Ming- C’yra -and Adora find Shadow Weaver and plot their revenge plan.

Wu Ming never reveals her true identity to Adora, not even when Adora whispers to Wu Ming one night that she's seeking revenge for her best friend, C'yra. Wu Ming has her chance, then, to just tell Adora that that is who she is- yet she doesn't.

He watches them as their conversation gets more personal- watches the two become wrapped up in each other, mouths pressed together helplessly, and his only thought-

"Why didn't you tell her?" He whispers, confused. "You had the opening- you could've told her.. Why didn't you?"

And C'yra, from her position, remembers what this is. A memory. It's not real. She turns, faces him.

"...Get out."

She doesn't want him watching anymore. These are her memories, memories she doesn't want to share with him.

Darkness again.

They're in the kiln again, clashing. Teeth, claws, swords- fighting to beat each other.

“You have a strong mind, little sister!” Shanyuan exclaims, countering one of her attacks. “I didn’t expect any of that, I’ll give it to you!”

C’yra groans as one of his cats latch onto her, forcing her to flick it off since she wasn’t able to devour it.

“Horde Prime- He was your brother!” She says through clenched teeth. “But I don’t understand- you’re one of the clones!?”

Shanyuan says nothing, just continues to battle.

“What plan did he have, since he obviously had one,” Her breathing was ragged. “For the creation of Ghost Kings? To help him? But- he’s dead!”

Shanyuan laughs hysterically. “He hasn’t changed, not one bit!” He laughs. “You truly believe that, little sister? Believe that he’s dead!? What a fool you are! You think it’s that easy!?”

“Yes! For the Emperor-” C’yra cries. “It is! They spread his ashes!”

“Fool, you’re a fool!” Shanyuan laughs again, still fighting effortlessly. “The Emperor couldn’t have spread his ashes- THERE

ARE NO ASHES TO SPREAD!”

C’yra was taken aback but such a statement, but she wouldn’t let it hinder her movements. “What!? There’s- There’s no way! You- How is that true?! Explain it to me- You can’t leave this place, so- so tell me, I’ll kill him for you-”

“DON’T YOU THINK I’VE TRIED THAT?” He yells. “I’ve tried everything! Nothing works- not against him! I’m not letting you out of here, little sister- and my decision is final.”

“Let me out, I swear I’ll kill him!” C’yra tries to reason- but it’s not use trying to reason with a mad man. She knows that best.

“I’VE TRIED, I’VE TRIED LITTLE SISTER-” He’s screaming, now. “BUT IT DOESN’T MATTER, BUT WHEN YOU LEAVE HERE, YOU WON’T REMEMBER ANY OF IT!”

That stuns her, this time. Truly stuns her. “How…” She whispers, trailing off and dodging another one of his attacks. She falls back, needing a break and to devour some of the cat apparitions.

And it hits her. He didn’t only steal Shanyuan’s name, but he stole his own name, his past..

And his magic, that type of magic, can’t reach Mount Tong’lu. It can keep him inside, but nothing he tells her- nothing she sees

from his memories about Horde Prime, about any of it, can leave.

He starts laughing again, so hysterically that he doesn't even progress forwards to try and fight her anymore. And finally, when he does stop- she's not there anymore.

The kiln itself isn't one big space- it's made up of tunnels, other caverns within it. C'yra retreats into those tunnels, hiding in a cavern. She needs to rest- needs to think of a plan.

Shanyuan knows what will happen next. They'll clash, and they'll retreat, then clash again. It's a never ending cycle.

They'll see each other's memories in full, C'yra will learn everything there is to know about the past, about Hordak, and then he will devour her.

Nothing moves quickly in Tong'lu, and the kiln is no exception. C'yra spends months, lurking in the shadows of the tunnels, moving deeper and deeper. She finds that he sleeps, for days and weeks at a time.

Every time he slumbers, C'yra thinks- and she works. She sculpts, still. It's a bit of an escape for her, and it gives her an excuse to think- because sculpting makes her think. Of her past, sure, but of how she can proceed

Her sculptures have gotten much better, she thinks. She knows her work has gotten better and…

The face that stares back at her now, it's perfect. No mistakes, nothing is off about it. It's exactly Adora- captures everything good about her perfectly.

C'yra, even in this place where she is constantly on edge, couldn't be happier with her creation.

"Look," She whispers to the hordes of Shanyuan's cats that litter her cavern- they don't attack her when he's sleeping. They've gotten used to her presence. "That's her. What do you think?"

The cats stare up at the statue- impossibly large, even with the height of the cavern. C'yra smiles at the statue, then looks at the horde of cats and- there, in the middle, is the very same cat that used to follow her around outside the kiln.

Curiously enough, she can feel its presence now that she knows it's there. The cat looks at her curiously and- she realizes that somehow along the way, the cat connected itself to her. She can hear its thoughts.

It's praising her work.

'Good,' they say. 'Better than rest.'

And she smiles, beckons the cat towards her- and it heeds her command. She lifts it up gently to be face to face with the sculpture.

Her greatest work, and it was the sculptures that were in every one of Adora's temples. Sword in one hand, flower in the other. She looked regal, looked heavenly.

'Beautiful,' she hears the cat say. 'Best work.'

"I know," she murmurs to the cat, petting its head and relishing in the way it purred. It calmed her. "I know it is."

She hears a sound behind her- the cat in her arms reacts to it as well, alerting her that she isn't imagining it. She turns fast, and- it isn't Shanyuan who's standing there.

It's Adora.

"Adora?" C'yra questions- she thinks she's imagining her. There's no way she isn't. "Is that.."

Adora smiles at her. She looks like how she did when C'yra last saw her- light blue robes with a white undergarment, fastened at the ends of the sleeves with a leather forearm guard. Wrapped

around the guards are ribbons, the same light blue color of the robes, and they're tied to keep the guards in place.

"Hey, Cy," Adora says softly and- that isn't an illusion. There's no way it can be. "Long time to see?"

Adora walks towards her now, grabbing her hands when she's close enough. "I didn't think you were still around," She whispers. "I thought you were gone by the time I got to the Fright Zone…"

She felt awestruck. This couldn't be happening.

"I thought she took you away from me before I could say goodbye," Adora continues, dragging her hands up C'yra's arms, up her shoulders and neck before landing on her face, cupping her cheeks. "And here you are."

"Here I am," C'yra confirms, voice breaking. "How are you-"

The look on Adora's face is sad, solemn. "Do you hate me?" She asks, voice breaking.

"Yes," C'yra bites out. "So much."

She can hear her own voice in the back of her head, whispering the same thing she wanted to scream at Shanyuan in his memories- 'tell her!'

"But I-"

"Love you?" Adora finishes, her voice a soft whisper. C'yra nods her head ferociously. Adora smiles again, as bright as the sun.

"My knight," Adora says, rubbing her thumb back and forth on her cheekbone. "My beautiful knight, look at how far you've come."

None of this makes sense to C'yra. How was Adora there? Why is she treating her the way she is? Does she mean it?

"You're my best friend, you know that?" Adora asks, her voice barely above a whisper. "You always have been, always will be.."

"What about-"

"Glimmer?" Adora finishes again, and she shakes her head. "You two are similar, but she'll never be you.."

Adora's voice is impossibly quiet, "...no one will ever be you."

C’yra reaches her hand up and cover’s Adora’s hand with her own- and it feels real. This- this was real. Adora was here, and she was saying all these things to her- and it felt like a dream.

Adora rests her forehead on C’yra’s and closes her eyes. “I didn’t mean to break our promise,” She confesses. “I never meant to break it. I just… I wanted- I thought I knew what I had to do, but it meant nothing without you.”

“I know,” C’yra murmurs, tracing every detail of Adora’s face. “I know you didn’t mean to- but you still did, and gods, I hate you… so much, but I still- I still love you.”

“I know you do,” Adora responds. “And I’m so, so grateful… I love you, too, you know.”

C’yra thinks she’s died again and this time, moved on. She feels like she’s floating.

She knows now how it feels to watch life pass you by and never make a move on the person who you hold the most dear. She doesn’t want that to happen to her- not here, not in this place.

She connects her and Adora’s lips- and it isn’t soft and sweet, like their first kiss when they were 13, no.. this, this is full of want,

need. It’s hot and it’s fast, and it’s ferocious. It’s the way she had always wanted to kiss Adora, the way she never got to.

She clings to Adora- and Adora clings to her just the same.

And Adora pushes herself up against C’yra- in fact, moves them to be against the cavern wall, moving to trail her lips down C’yra’s neck and-

Something isn’t right.

She’s had many fantasies regarding Adora- fighting her, kissing her, being with her.. And her imagination is vast, but never once has she imagined something like this.

She’s never imagined a universe where Adora would say, or do, any of these things. Not even in her more… shameful fantasies, she never imagined this- never imagined Adora stating C’yra’s insecurities and… reassuring her. She never thought she was worthy of the reassurance, especially not from Adora- and towards the end, she never wanted the reassurance from her.

This delusion, it isn’t meant to cause her fear… not meant to cause her pain, suffering. It’s meant to soothe, to distract.

Distract from someone getting devoured, maybe.

She knows what this is. It’s a distraction, a projection of her greatest regret in her life that she never got to experience, yet wanted to- and it indulges her. It lets her live it out, as a small mercy.

Meanwhile, in reality, she's slowly- but surely -getting devoured.

She looks harder at the Adora that has her pressed against the wall- and she sees it now, the way her teeth are sharp as knives, her jaw opening slightly more and more.

He lunges, and C’yra just barely avoids it by ducking down, digging her claws into the ground and running on all fours down the tunnel.

“Why couldn’t you have just enjoyed it, little sister!” Shanyuan yells, running to catch up with her.

“No one is going to devour me!” She yells back, panting. She knows what she has to do- she feels it.

“I can’t let you leave here, little sister!” He sounds so desperate, boots slamming onto the ground causing the ground to rumble. “Let’s just get this over with!”

C’yra ignores what he says- “How are the wraith cats formed,” She has to physically force the word out of her mouth, “..big brother?”

“GIVE IT UP!”

C’yra sighs. She thought she could delay it, but it’s no use.

She turns completely, and for the first time in over a year, bounds down the tunnel and enters the main cavern of the kiln.

Unbeknownst to her, Shanyuan was already there- and she runs straight into him.

The world is pitch black for a moment.

And then there is crying- of a baby.

And the baby grows to be a child, around 7 years of age.

It’s a girl.

Selene sat in the garden, watching her daughter play with the stray cats, and next to her sat Selvyn.

Selvyn was aware of how long it took for them to conceive their third- their last -child. Selene blamed him for his death, but she got used to the idea of Selvyn being a robot.

"It doesn't matter," She had said. "Everyone dies. It's still your soul in there… just not your body."

And he trusted her, that she didn't mind.

His niece was fiery, and she was witty, but she was the sweetest girl he had ever met. He was proud to call her his niece- he was proud to have someone like her be his niece. He loved her so much.

Almost a millenia later, another girl would come around who would remind him of his niece- Catarina. She'd remind him so fiercely of his niece that he would swear her soul reincarnated and found him again.

Selene tells her daughter of her two brothers- but she tells her that they became butterflies who flew away.

"I'll be a butterfly, one day!" Catarina exclaimed happily. Selene smiled softly at her daughter, "But then you'll fly away from me,

won’t you?”

“No!” Catarina huffs. “I’d stay with you, or- or I’d try to bring you with me… but, butterflies die..”

“Everything dies,” Selene reminds her gently. Catarina pouts, then scowls. “Why?”

“Because,” Selvyn speaks up. “Every banquet in the world has to come to an end, Cat.”

Catarina is quiet after that, softly petting the cat. “I’ll be a cat, then.” She decides. “Not a butterfly. Cat’s live forever!”

“Why, they die too.” Selene says. “They don’t live forever.”

“No, but cats come back!” Catarina smiles brightly up at them, contrasting her sun-tanned skin and dark freckles. “They have 9 lives, so even if they die once, they still have 8 lives! Plus- I’ll always come back!”

The seasons shift and change, the child grows.

When she’s 10, the earthquakes begin. Selvyn suggests it’s the volcano that the kingdom is built around- while it’s been dormant

for years, it doesn't mean an eruption isn't possible. Selene decides to keep an eye on it, to prepare the kingdom for evacuations if needed.

And that was truly the plan, until Selene's idiot husband descended from heaven, declaring he had a dream and they needed to listen to him.

He details how in the dream, the volcano erupts, completely obliterating the kingdom. He insists that the only way to appease it's wrath is to sacrifice people to the volcano. He suggests criminals- ones on death row already.

"Have you gone insane!?" Selvyn yells at his brother- his brother, who he always stood by and supported. His brother, who has become selfish. "We can't sacrifice people!"

"They're criminals!" Helios yells right back. "War criminals, from Brightmoon, Eternia! On Death Row! It doesn't make a difference!"

"It's still sacrifice!" Galen yells.

C'yra watches the fight that ensues- between Helios and his family, arguing that human sacrifices are not what will stop a volcano from erupting. He says he's doing it in Catarina's honor- that she's the reason he's suggesting the sacrifice. But he is outweighed by the majority- of which are saying that he has no

authority over the Prime Kingdom anymore, not since he ascended.

The Prime Kingdom has a Queen, and it's her decision to make.

The Queen looks the other way, after much meditation and debating on the matter at hand. She is not swift when looking into the disappearance of several criminals on death row. She chooses to look forward to the future.

Selvyn can't believe that she let him do it. That she looked the other way.

Selene makes Selvyn promise that if worse comes to pass, he takes her daughter and runs.

Catarina turns 12, and the first eruption shakes the kingdom. The Royal Court survives, but almost all of the farmland is destroyed with it.

The volcano still rumbles.

With the continuing rumbling, Helios suggests another idea: a bridge to the heavens, in which everyone can fit and escape the catastrophic eruption.

It’s a stupid idea, ludicrous and impossible. But they believe him- because he is their god, and he knows best.

Selene didn’t believe for a second that her husband could do it.

But he did. He built a bridge- not a real one, but one made out of magic, to the heavens. So, when the second eruption hit, the third, the fourth- all in quick succession -the people of the Prime Kingdom were already climbing the bridge.

Galen, Anastas, Selvyn- all three of them were clones already. They had no need to climb the bridge, they’d survive regardless.

Selene, Catarina- they weren’t clones. They were climbing the bridge, and for a second.. Selvyn truly believed that his brother had done it, and that he- and everyone else -was stupid for mistrusting their god.

And then the golden bridge begins to flicker, before giving out completely. Selvyn watches hundreds, thousands of his people fall into volcanic ash, into lava. He can hear the agonizing screams, and he’s absolutely sure they will haunt him forever.

And in the middle of it all, was Selene and Catarina.

Selene brought the Sword of Protection with her- and it was the only thing keeping her away from the lava… but she wasn’t quick

enough to save Catarina, her only daughter.

Selvyn can hear her scream loud and clear, agonized and grief-struck.

The blade guides her to them, deposits her next to Selvyn. She sinks to her knees, howling, crying, screaming. Selvyn knows better than to try and touch her.

He watches with his brothers, watches as his home- his kingdom - is destroyed.

They stay there, stuck in time. Even when Selene leaves, goes to Eternia. They're still there when she comes back. They watch as she fights ghosts, goblins, everything under the sun until one day-

She goes mad. She tries to perform a soul summoning ritual, to summon the soul of Catarina and put her into one of the clones.

They watch her destroy herself. She dies on the spot, but they know- they know she'll be back, with a vengeance.

And they are still there when she comes back, a savage ghost.

"...He says he knows where she is," She says to them, face horribly deformed. "He says the bridge failed because the other gods backed out last minute- that they had agreed to help and then bailed."

"What do you want us to do, your majesty?" Galen asks in their stead.

"I need… swords," She murmurs. "Selvyn, forge the finest blades you can. Five of them- one for each. You'll help us, won't you?"

They don't ask what they'll be helping with. They just accept it as it was. He felt like he wasn't controlling his own mind, his own body- he felt as though he was being controlled.

He forges 5 of the finest blades in the world- only behind the Sword of Protection.

And then she requests other kinds of weapons- polearms, bows, sabers. He forges them all, all of them cursed and powerful. One by one, he creates an entire infantry of weapons for them all to use.

They find out exactly what the plan is the day of.

A massacre. A bloody, horrific massacre. A slaughtering of the heavenly dynasty, led by a madman and a woman on her way to

going insane.

She uses shadow magic to trap the heavenly officials, then tortures them in the name of her daughter. Helios is quicker with it, aiming to end this as quickly as possible.

Selvyn, his brothers- they didn't want to do it. But they had to, were compelled to do it, as if they were being controlled by someone else.

Selvyn learns the truth from the wind master, whose injuries were already fatal- he learns that they never agreed to help with the bridge.

He realizes then that he sacrificed his niece. It was not a horrific accident. It was purposeful.

He resents his brother for taking her away from him- from them.

He plunges his sword through the chest of his brother the second he sees him. It was the only time he didn't feel as though he was being controlled.

He doesn't stop plunging the sword into him, even when he yells about how even his own brother has turned on him- his brother, his clone.

“You are a greedy, selfish…” Selvyn seethes, plunging the sword in his body, over and over and over again. “Terrible excuse of a man, of a god!”

The others were long gone. They didn’t know what was going on between the two twins.

“I’ve lived in your shadow my whole life,” Selvyn cries. “For what? For you to get everything good- to get the girl, the crown, the children, the glory… just to give it all up! To sacrifice it, for no good reason! Big brother, you’re an idiot, you are selfish, and- and evil! You’re evil! Despicable!”

“Everything I’ve done was in the name of my family!” Helios screams, wriggling beneath the blade that plunges relentlessly into his body.

“Liar!” Selvyn shouts. “Everything you’ve done was for yourself, and yourself only! Not once have you made a decision to benefit your family!”

He leaves him there, bleeding on the manicured bricks of heaven.

He descends to the ruins of the palace gardens, and he sits among the stray cats. They aren't the same cats from before- no,

those are long dead, but these.. they are made from pure spiritual power. From magic.

How does one forge the wraith cats?

Well, magic- and spiritual power -they are no different than any kind of energy that is in the universe. It comes from a core, and magic comes from a person's core.

The core can be passed on and made stronger through generations, it can be strengthened by practice or, if you're a god, by prayers.

Souls are similar. In order to forge these creatures, you need to first know that ghosts are just ghost fires given shape.

And when you understand the shape of your soul, can you mold it.

And Shanyuan- well, he believed souls are like cats. They never truly die, because dead is not gone, as he had learned. Everyone, every soul is out there somewhere. Everyone has multiple lives- 9 lives, in his belief.

He sits among his wraith cats, praying to whatever God may hear him to let him rest in peace. He's not sure if he can even pass on, with his soul infused in a robot clone of his brother. But he prays,

and he prays, wishing for the day to come where he can pass on peacefully.

He sits there, frozen in time again. He hears news of his brothers ascension to the heavenly throne- the Emperor, side by side with his Empress, Selene.

He blames Selvyn for the downfall of the old heavenly dynasty. He becomes hunted, all sorts of gods seeking him out and trying to kill him- and he can't die. As much as he wishes he can, he can't.

He hears word of the army of clones his brother has created, he called it "the horde" and he, the leader. Lord Prime.

He comes and finds him one day, and curses him anew. Strips his once beloved brother of his name, all of his titles. He binds him to the land, confined to the space, cursed to never be able to leave and never tell the truth of what he did to the world.

He still tries, though. Tries with each half-baked monster that he lets exit the kiln. He prays that someone will can and free him, let him rest in peace.

He creates a new name for himself. 'Shanyuan', it means Mountain Spirit in Kingdom of Snows. He finds it fitting, because that's what he is, isn't he? The very spirit that haunts Mount Tong'lu, praying for release- or for someone to finally see the truth and to end his brother once and for all.

The first one who enters the kiln who he believes has the potential to be a calamity he names Galen, after his beloved brother.

But he knows- knows once he leaves he will forget the truth.

So he doesn't let him leave.

The next comes almost a century after Galen. This one he names Randor, after his son whom he lost.

But again he knows- when he leaves, he will forget, and Shanyuan won't.

So he doesn't let him leave, either.

And then the kiln doesn't open for centuries, a millenia. He believes the cycles been broken, that his soul can finally pass on.

And then the gates rattles open, stronger than before, and she knows when the girl comes crashing down how this will end.

He names her Catarina in his head. Cat, for short.

His chain of memories ends and he expects to be in the kiln again, and he isn't.

There's a heart beating in his chest, as he looks around the moonlit garden. Selene is next to him, her head on his shoulder, and a little boy is sat in her lap. In his lap is his niece, Catarina. Off in the distance is an older man, but he knows- that would've been Selene's first son, had he not gotten his soul stolen.

He feels happy. He's playing with Catarina, bouncing her up and down on his leg.

But she stops suddenly, hugging him tightly.

"I'm sorry," She murmurs to him. "I'm so sorry, uncle."

He's confused. Why should she ever feel the need to apologize to him? She's never done anything wrong. He lets her know that fact and yet she continues. She repeats it over, and over, and over.

He feels a stabbing pain in his neck, as though his insides were being ripped out. She continues to apologize. The pain gets worse, moves to his abdomen, and she doesn't relent.

And then it doesn't hurt anymore. Its peaceful, sitting there with his makeshift family.

Catarina keeps apologizing.

"Can I stay here?" He asks her softly. She nods.

"Of course you can," She says. "You can stay for as long as you want…. until I free you."

He lies there, staring up at the ceiling of of his kiln, a new ghost king overhead devouring him.

"I'm sorry," She weeps. "Gods, I'm so sorry-"

and around him are wraith cats. And he's proud, so so proud of her.

"You did it," he whispers. "You learned how to forge them…. I'm so, so proud of you, little sister…"

"I'm sorry," is all she says. "I'm so sorry!"

"You shouldn't apologize when you win," He laughs quietly. "...don't disappoint me, little sister."

She's crying, staring down at the man who she sees as a brother.

"I won't," She promises him, voice cracking. "I swear I won't."

He closes his eyes then, a smile on his face.

She knows he's passed on when the kiln slowly begins to open, sunlight peaking in through every Crack. Sunlight she hasn't seen in years.

She feels the warmth of the sun, and she feels the rush of power surging into her body. It's intoxicating, it's power she's never known before.

She's done it, she's entered Mount Tong'lu and left it as a calamity. As a Ghost King.

She can leave, she knows. Yet she still drops to her knees next to Shanyuans body and kowtows before him, uttering small prayers for him.

"Thank you, Your Highness Selvyn." She mutters, standing up and dusting off her robes.

She exits the kiln. She knows the second she steps foot out of Mount Tong'lu, she will forget everything.

But she has an idea, when her eyes catch on a hammer when she looks back. She steps back into the kiln, she lights a fire, she heats up Melog and the hammer.

She forges every memory that she has, everything she learned from Shanyuan into the blade. Hatred, vengeance, she hammers all of it into Melog. Layer upon layer, she forges.

She will forget, but Melog won't. Spiritual tools, they are what you make of them, and one day… she will remember.

Melog is essentially a new blade, after that. The blade itself is longer, sharper, more powerful. The hilt is more refined, and she couldn't be happier with it.

The cat appears again, at her side. She smiles down at it, pets its hhead. She watches the cat grow in size to be about the size of a lion, all while she continues to pet its head.

She'll figure out a way, later, to combine the cat and the blade to make it one. She knows that if there is a will, there is a way, and

the blade is already sentient…

But now is not the time.

She exits the kiln again, and she knows she will make time to figure it out.

For now, she has things she has to do- people she has to free. But she has time, she has so much time. It's a new age.

For the first time in over 7 centuries, a new era begins.

The Era of the Crimson Night Striking Mercilessly.

Chapter End Notes

Gods I quoted soooo many things in this. so so so many. just want to first apologize for any spelling mistakes or formatting errors; I'm once again uploading this from my phone, with no beta reader.

Second, THANK TOJ SO MUCH FOR STICKING THIS THROUGH WITH ME! this was such a fun thing to write and I loved every second. I didn't expect this chapter to be so lore heavy, but I hope you guys enjoyed this!!!! I skipped over a lot of the catta/adora scenes because I think I'll expand more on those in a fic of their own one day.... if you guys want!

can you guys believe the first kiss of this universe was between a straight couple? i evened it out by the end, thankfully. I'm gonna try to write adoras interlude fic next, but I honestly might just go straight into the next fic of the present timeline. Let me know your guys' thoughts on this fic, as well as what you'd rather see next: adora's interlude fic or the next installment of the present timeline?? Once again, i hope you and enjoyed and dont forget to comment!!! see you guys in the next fic :)))

End Notes

goooooooooood evening/morning/afternoon (from whenever you're all reading this). Decided to knock out Catra's interlude first, since it's gonna take the longest to write (5 chapters! I have this planned to be around 5 chapters!)
I have a lot planned for this, and I'm excited to write it all. I apologize for this chapter being slow, I promise things will pick up in chapter 2 when I finish writing it (It's already in the works, I promise!)

Anyways, thank you all so much for reading, I hope you're as excited to read this as I am to write it. I hope you all enjoyed it, and if you did please let me know! Your comments and kudos are very much welcome, as they motivate me to write.
I love all of you, and I'll see you in the next chapter!
(as a side note, you can find my twitter here! I post fic updates, as well as just other stuff. Please come talk to me :))

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!